

NPCR campaign rescues over 3,800 from child labour

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

NEW DELHI

One lavatory commode came off, while a crew seat and other components near the rear doors were also damaged.

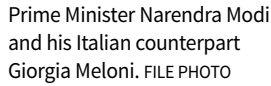
The Child Rights Commission undertook coordinated measures with the concerned State Governments/Union Territory administrations, district magistrates, labour departments, police authorities and other stakeholders to intensify the identi-

To monitor implementation and address field-level issues, the NCPCH held meetings with the district administrations. The meetings focused on reviewing rescue operations, addressing operational bottlenecks and strengthening coordination among the concerned departments.

Two held for sexual abuse of students in Bihar school

In their statement countering the argument of the government on why it did not use the OBC lists, the AIOBCSA said this logic becomes “even more questionable when certificates and official records routinely identify communities by their specific social and caste identities. Even EWS certificates identify the beneficiary through prescribed social/category criteria, demonstrating that administrative classification and social identity can coexist”.

Ms. Meloni, 49, has been Italy's Prime Minister since October 22, 2022. On Thursday, after 1,413 days in office, she became the country's longest-serving uninterrupted Prime Minister since the Second

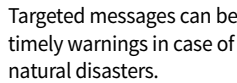


"Congratulations to my friend Prime Minister Meloni on becoming the longest continuously serving Prime Minister in Italy's postwar history. This milestone is a reflection of the trust and confidence of the Italian people in her leadership," Mr. Modi said in a post on X. He said that Ms. Meloni's friendship had also been instrumental in strengthening the India-Italy Special Strategic Partnership.

The action came after a complaint was lodged by a student's mother. Police are conducting searches to locate the other accused teacher.

Emergency broadcasting of weather and natural disaster alerts resumed: C-DOT CEO

“One message has to reach every operator’s core and every kind of radio – Motorola, Siemens, ZTE, Huawei – and even within one vendor, a 2G version-1 radio differs from version-2,” Mr. Upadhyay



Germany-headquartered Utimaco, a global provider of the technology, had sued the government in the Delhi High Court over its decision to hand over the CBS project to the

While C-DOT is known for enabling rural telephone exchanges in the last century, the Union government has charged the body with coming up with domestically manufactured alternatives to telecom gear.

275 Indians still missing, 169 rescued, says Ministry

Kallol Bhattacharjee
NEW DELHI

INBRIEF



Army kills one terrorist in forest area of J&K's Budgam

One terrorist was killed on Friday during a joint operation by the Army and Jammu and Kashmir Police deep inside a forest area in Budgam district, officials said. The operation was launched based on information about the movement of a suspected group of terrorists from Pulwama district towards Budgam, the officials said. “Based on specific intelligence input, a joint search operation was launched by the Indian Army, J&K Police and CRPF in Ashdar Gali, Budgam,” the Srinagar-based Chinara Corps posted on X. The operation is under way as the forces are still looking for another terrorist, who is believed to be holed up in the same area. PTI

58 patients rescued as fire erupts in Maharashtra hospital

A fire broke out at Asian Hospital in Chhatrapati Sambhajanagar in Maharashtra, following which 58 patients, including nine newborns, were rescued. According to the hospital authorities, the newborns were shifted to the nearby Ghati Hospital, MGM Hospital, and Sanjeevani Hospital. The incident occurred around 2.15 a.m. due to a short circuit in an AC unit in the NICU. “The duty staff noticed smoke coming out of AC and immediately activated the code red, using their presence of mind, and evacuated the newborns,” said Shoaib Hashmi, managing director, Asian Hospital, adding that they managed to avoid a big tragedy because the hospital fire system is intact.

SC pushes for raising retirement age in district judiciary as backlog tops 5 cr.

Top court says it is ‘crying need of the hour’ to stop attrition of experienced judicial talent otherwise access to justice would remain a mere chimera; only 7 States have responded positively to SC’s call, while others are hesitant or plain fence-sitting

Krishnadas Rajagopal
NEW DELHI

As 5.18 crore cases lie pending in district courts across the country, the Supreme Court has sent a distress call to States to enhance the retirement age of experienced judicial officers from 60 to 62 years.

The court said the “crying need of the hour” is to stop the attrition of the experienced judicial talent lest access to justice remain a mere chimera due to unfilled posts.

Only seven States have so far responded positively to the SOS from the Supreme Court. Chhattisgarh, Karnataka, Madhya Pradesh, Maharashtra, Sikkim, Tamil Nadu and West Bengal have agreed to enhance the retirement age of their judicial officers.

A three-judge Bench headed by Chief Justice of India Surya Kant, in a September 1 order published on Friday, directed these State governments to amend the service rules within two months. The State High Court concerned would enhance the age of superannuation to 62 years of judicial officers,

Most of the recruitment drives undertaken in the various States have not resulted in optimum recruitment or in the filling up of the sanctioned cadre strength, and a yawning gap between the sanctioned and working strength persists across the board

SUPREME COURT



subject to their suitability assessment, on their attainment of 60 years of age.

The other States and Union Territories have varied between a direct negative response to plain fence-sitting.

The court has directed them to take a decision on enhancement of retirement age of their judicial officers to 62 years in two weeks. These States include Andhra Pradesh, Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Bihar, Goa, Gujarat, Haryana, Himachal Pradesh, Jharkhand, Keralam, Manipur, Meghalaya, Mizoram, Nagaland, Odisha, Punjab, Rajasthan, Telangana, Tripura, Uttarakhand, Uttar Pradesh, NCT of Delhi, Jammu and Kash-

mir, and Puducherry.

Their hesitation, the court discovered, was fuelled by a sense of insecurity over the financial burden the move would entail. Plus, these States apprehend that employees in other State services would also demand parity.

The Bench said the apprehensions of these States were entirely misconceived. Judicial officers do a specialised service.

Benefit to society

“The alleged financial burden that would be thrown on the State exchequer on account of the enhancement of the superannuation age as a result of the payment of the maximum salary in the pay scale to the officers for a further

period of two or five years as the case may be, and on account of the higher outlay on their retiral benefits, is negligible considering the enormous advantage that the administration of justice and the society at large would derive from the enhancement in the age of retirement,” the Bench quoted a 1992 judicial precedent.

Besides, the court said simple math showed that a State, by retaining the retirement age of 60 years, would double-spend post-retiral dues of superannuated judicial officers as well as pay the salaries of the newly-appointed ones.

On the contrary, if experienced members of the judicial cadre were permitted to continue in service till the age of 62, the additional burden of bearing such post-retiral dues would stand correspondingly postponed.

Besides, the recruitment of independent and competent judicial officers was an arduous task.

“Most of the recruitment drives undertaken in the various States have not resulted in optimum recruitment or in the filling up of the sanctioned cadre

strength, and a yawning gap between the sanctioned and working strength persists across the board,” the court pointed out.

The Bench pointed out that most State High Courts have consented to the enhancement of the retirement age as they were face-to-face with the “crisis in dispensation of justice”.

Some High Courts, including Madras, the court recorded has “wisely” introduced relevant riders so that the deadwood did not take advantage of the proposal to enhance superannuation age. These High Courts have recommended a thorough assessment of judicial work as a condition precedent to ensure that only competent officers of proven integrity were permitted to continue in the cadre.

“This suggestion is most welcome as it would balance the preservation of experienced judicial officers, while removing the clog of deadwood, blocking the entrance of young blood invigorating the system,” the Supreme Court observed.

The court listed the case again on October 1.

HC seeks NTA response on UGC-NET re-test plea

The Hindu Bureau
NEW DELHI

The Delhi High Court has sought a response from the National Testing Agency and the Centre on a plea challenging the decision to re-conduct the UGC-NET June 2026 examination for the English subject.

The English and Commerce tests will be re-conducted on September 9, while the Sociology paper on September 10.

The court’s direction came in response to a plea by a candidate who appeared in the UGC-NET June 2026 examination. It also directed authorities to make a decision regarding refund of the examination fee for the concerned examination. The court listed the matter for further hearing on October 6.

Petitioner Parul Sheoran sought a direction from the court to quash the August 16 notice issued by the NTA, which directed the re-conduct of the examination for English.

It claimed that the decision to re-conduct the examination was taken without disclosing the material forming its basis and without following the procedure prescribed under the UGC-NET June 2026 Information Bulletin.

Over 17,000 shifted to safer places amid floods in U.P.

The Hindu Bureau
LUCKNOW

More than 17,500 people have been evacuated from 26 flood-affected districts across Uttar Pradesh, with no loss of life or livestock reported so far, the State government said on Friday. Eight rivers are flowing above the danger mark.

The Relief Commissioner’s office said around 3.53 lakh people have been affected by the floods, while 4,847 people are currently staying in relief shelters. “A total of 72,897 flood relief kits and more than 3.67 lakh lunch packets have been distributed among affected families,” said Relief Commissioner’s Office.

As part of health safety measures, more than 5.52 lakh chlorine tablets and over 1.87 lakh ORS packets have also been distributed to the displaced people.

NTA seeks AICTE help to establish centres for computer-based tests

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has sought the help of the All India Council for Technical Education (AICTE) to map IT infrastructure and vacant spaces in government institutions to establish standard testing centres (STCs). These centres will facilitate computer-based testing (CBT) for NTA examinations, including the high-stakes National Eligibility-cum-Entrance Test (NEET).

The NTA plans to shift NEET to CBT mode next year. Nearly 22 lakh students appeared for the NEET-UG, 2026, which was held in a pen-and-paper format. The examination became embroiled in a paper leak controversy and had to be re-conducted, leading to widespread protests and the resignation of Dharmendra Prad-



The NTA plans to shift NEET to CBT mode next year. The NEET-UG 2026 was held in a pen-and-paper format. ANI

han as Union Education Minister.

Infrastructure audit

Following the NTA’s request, the AICTE wrote to Vice-Chancellors of government-run technical universities and heads of AICTE-approved government institutes on August 31 to assess their infrastructure.

The AICTE has directed all approved government

engineering colleges, polytechnics, university departments, and technical as well as management institutes to submit comprehensive data regarding their facilities by September 15.

The move follows an NTA directive issued on August 5 to address the progressive migration of national-level examinations to online and CBT modes. “By establishing

STCs in government institutions, the NTA seeks to create a wider, highly secure, and geographically distributed network of testing hubs,” the NTA officials said.

The AICTE has emphasised that this data collection is strictly restricted to government-owned and approved institutes.

To ensure seamless exam delivery without technical glitches, the NTA and AICTE are assessing local and external networks for Internet connectivity.

Power failures during high-stakes exams lead to the risk of re-conducting exams. Hence, AICTE has stated that institutes must detail their electrical back-up capabilities. Furthermore, details on surveillance systems are sought, requiring information on existing CCTV coverage across all labs and connecting corridors.

82 educators set to receive National Teachers’ Awards

Maitri Porecha
NEW DELHI

An asteroid hunter. A Maths wizard. A trailblazer in a coal mining community. A Special Olympics hockey coach. These are among the 82 educators from across the country who will receive the National Teachers’ Awards on Saturday. President Droupadi Murmu will confer the awards.

Among the awardees are 48 school teachers, 21 faculty members in higher education, and 13 trainers from the Union Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship. Among the faculty in higher education are proponents of Indian Knowledge Systems, including Vaastu Shastra, Bhagavad Gita, and others.

One of the awardees, Haryana-based Anil Kaushik, known as the ‘Math Wi-

Among the awardees are 48 school teachers, 21 faculty members in higher education, and 13 trainers from MSDE

zard’, built a state-of-the-art physical Maths lab containing over 40 original learning models, alongside a 12-section virtual mathematics lab with 30 ‘Harbans puzzles’.

He has co-authored textbooks on Vedic Mathematics and published 22 teaching modules on the national DIKSHA portal.

Divyendu Sen from Rajasthan, another recipient of the award, is a teacher in a government school who bridged rural classrooms with deep-space science by training local students to track and hunt asteroids. He has pioneered low-cost solutions, including an AI-

enabled Biology education model, a Virtual Biology Laboratory, and ‘Tree Talk’, a QR-based botanical learning system.

Rajasthan-based teacher Vartika Gulati is an awardee who teaches at the Government Girls Upper Primary School in Jaipur. She turns abstract concepts into everyday experiences – teaching Algebra with groundnuts and geometry with kites. Her initiative, *Prashno Se Vigyan* (Science through questions), replaces rote learning with student-led inquiry.

Odisha-based teacher Padaraj Nayak, based at the Government High School, Alipingal, is receiving the award for guiding students to build over 50 prototypes, including a low-cost automatic plate-washing machine that earned a Government of India patent.



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CROSSWORD

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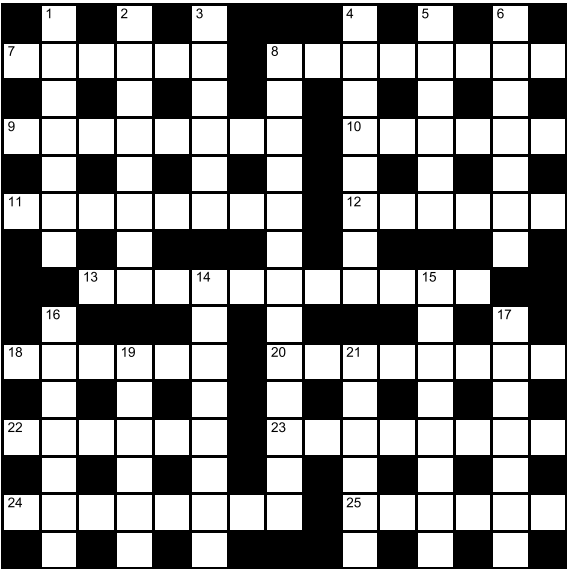
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(set by Pixie Dust)

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SCAN TO PLAY



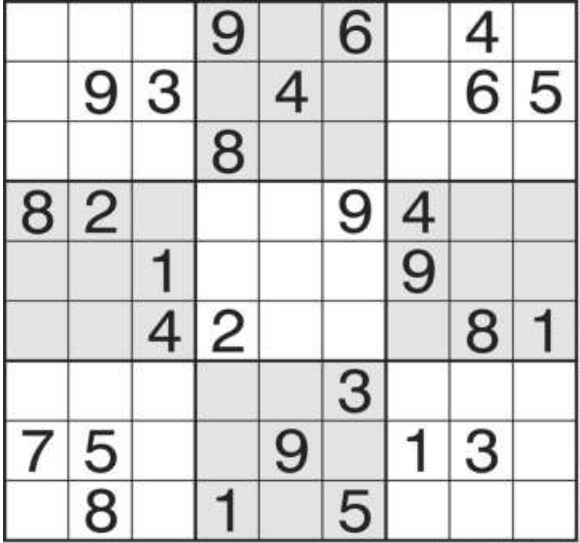


Across

- 7 Extremely corrupt amateur (egghead) agent missing now and then (6)
8 Forego pals? Not so casually in child’s play (8)
9 Topped stretching in workout (8)
10 Exiled man in Germany refused entry to begin with (6)
11 Doubt dead legends? (4,4)

- 12 Dismiss wriggling of a fly (3-3)
13 Ya! Count over and over in book-keeping? (11)
18 A Republican member of parliament has appeal in sweater? (6)
20 Gasp! I ran towards hiding suitor (8)
22 Elistit returns first class miniature plant (6)
23 Formless, trendy confectionery? No, pass! (8)
24 Rich Neapolitan Sauce from one of New York’s Five Families (8)
25 A grave tribute? (6)
Down
1 Runner’s back around end of June with Professor’s reward (7)
2 Once in a while, every idiotic criminal losing it perhaps (8)
3 Live? So soon! Will I win debate finally (6)
4 Animal upset about bloomer (8)
5 Some enjoy GIF featuring revolutionary figure (6)
6 Bluff about extremely feisty char (7)
8 Kindling Spooner’s conflict with a story-teller? (8,1,4)
14 Devil came through? (8)
15 Doh! These ride sharing arrangements made a mess of a school drop? (3,5)
16 Impudent when cycling around upright, humble cavalryman (7)
17 To some extent buffoons tag equilibrists in view of the audience (7)
19 Handgun’s part of a blossom, we hear (6)
21 Spot alien’s bag (6)

SUDOKU



Solution to previous puzzle

D	M	R	L	S	U			
B	I	G	E	P	A	I	N	T
C	T	D	E	F	O	W		
S	T	R	A	N	G	E	R	
I	P	U	F	L	T	I	N	
B	O	N	H	O	M	I	E	
N	O		C	N				
		B	R	E	A	K		
S		R	I		T	H	E	
M	O	T	M	O	R	A	T	O
B	A	N	N	E	R			
L	I	T	S	E	I			
K	I	L	O	W	A	T		
A	N	L		S	G	F		

Solution to yesterday’s Sudoku

6	9	4	5	2	8	3	7	1
2	7	5	3	4	1	6	9	8
3	8	1	9	6	7	5	2	4
8	5	9	6	1	4	7	3	2
7	4	2	8	9	3	1	6	5
1	3	6	2	7	5	4	8	9
5	6	7	1	8	2	9	4	3
9	2	3	4	5	6	8	1	7
4	1	8	7	3	9	2	5	6

FAITH

Gugga Navami

Janmashtami falls on the Ashtami thithi of Krishna Paksha in the month of Bhadrapada during the Rohini nakshatra. Sri Krishna is regarded as the eighth avatar of Vishnu. It commemorates the birth of Bala Gopal, which is believed to have taken place with miraculous celestial intervention, said Prof. Kumool Abbi.

Kamsa, the king of Mathura was the brother of Devaki. It had been prophesised that the eighth child of Devaki would lead to the death of the evil Kamsa. Therefore, Devaki and her husband Vasudev were imprisoned and all children born to them were killed. Spiritual literature states that divine intervention put Mathura to sleep and Vasudev saved baby Krishna after birth from Kamsa’s clutches and handed him over to the care of Yashoda and Nanda, eventually paving the way for the destruction of Kamsa.

Usually, the day after Janmashtami is observed as Gugga Naumi (Navami), a popular folk religious festival celebrated across Rajasthan, Haryana, Punjab, Jammu and Kashmir, Uttar Pradesh and other parts of north India. Gugga Naumi reflects the syncretic and fluid traditions of India, where He is worshipped by people of different religions and sects.

The celebration of Gugga Naumi begins on the day of the Rakhi and continues for nine days, beginning with pilgrimage to Gugga Medi village in Hanumangarh district of Rajasthan. Devotional songs called ‘pir ke solle’ are sung by the *gugga mandlis*, prayers and fairs take place at Gugga’s shrines, called *marhis*, dotted across villages in north India, reflecting Gugga’s affinity with the subalterns.



Warning on warming

India must shed its victim mindset while acting on climate change

The United Nations Environment Programme’s report, Limiting Overshoot, is a reminder that breaching the 1.5°C global warming limit would bring irreversible losses that adaptation cannot undo. Were all countries to deliver on their climate pledges today, the globe is still poised to heat 1.8°C and on current policies, 2.6°C. Given that the limit has already been breached – and, with the ongoing heating in the central equatorial Pacific expected to burgeon into one of the strongest El Niños in recent history, likely again in 2027 – the report is an acceptance of the scientific reality that we are in a 1.5°C world, while resisting the conclusion that nothing more can be done. The authors describe an “overshoot, peak and decline” pathway under which average global temperatures rise above 1.5°C but countries collectively hold the peak as low as possible and then bring them back below the limit by the end of the century. Neutralising the heating effect of even a tenth of a degree, the report argues, is far harder than preventing that rise in the first place. This in itself is nothing new. What is new is the emphasis on greenhouse gases beyond carbon dioxide. Action on methane, responsible for about 0.5°C of current warming, is considered the most effective way to slow warming in the near-term. Over 155 countries – India is not among them – have joined the Global Methane Pledge to cut anthropogenic methane at least 30% below 2020 levels by 2030.

That absence reflects the familiar tension between reports of this nature, which emphasise mitigation, and major developing economies such as India. They stress that they are already en route to moving away from fossil fuels and, being vulnerable to the impacts of historical stocks of carbon, deserve greater financial support and affordable technology from richer developed countries responsible for the crisis. The latest report unfortunately has little to say on adaptation finance, though there are previous assessments on the topic. With countries set to convene in Türkiye in November for COP31, familiar disagreements are likely to surface – but in the aftermath of the Bhotekoshi disaster in Nepal, India’s position too has been complicated. Nepal’s Foreign Affairs Minister, Shisir Khanal, has said that major industrial emitters such as China, the United States and India must consider the impact of rising temperatures on small countries such as Nepal. For India, this list means that a section of the world – despite India’s position as a victim of climate change with below-world-average per capita emissions – sees it as part of the problem. India must take such perceptions seriously and, rather than ignore the reality of a 1.5°C world, should calibrate its messaging to adapt to it.

Out of neglect bin

The perimenopausal policy will ease access to care for women in midlife

Women’s health care can be accused of being focused entirely on the reproductive age group. Menopause, for instance, is a natural transition phase, but even when its symptoms are severe and debilitating, women seldom have access to health care, and are forced to ‘just endure’. Given the huge care gap that exists here, it is appreciable that Tamil Nadu and Karnataka have taken the step to move ahead with the announcement of a perimenopause/menopause policy. Both the States made the announcement within a short while of each other, in August. The primary benefit, besides retrieving women’s mid-life care from the neglect bin it has been languishing in so far, is that the physical and mental-health needs of women in this stage of life will become part of routine government health care, making access to care easier. Tamil Nadu Health Minister K.G. Arunraj made the announcement of a perimenopausal care policy in the Assembly on August 17. He said the aim was to facilitate early identification of physical and mental health needs of perimenopausal women, with screening, counselling and treatment services through PHCs and higher centres. On August 4, Karnataka Health and Family Welfare Minister U.T. Khader, introduced ‘Ruthu Thare’ as the country’s first dedicated women’s health policy with a strong focus on perimenopause and menopause, at a meeting in Bengaluru. Menopause is the permanent end of menstrual periods and reproductive ability, confirmed after 12 consecutive months without a cycle. It happens when the ovaries naturally slow down and produce lower levels of the hormones oestrogen and progesterone. The transition time, leading up to menopause, is the perimenopausal period which can bring irregular periods and bodily changes over several years. Common symptoms include hot flashes, sleep trouble, extreme mood changes, joint pain, debility and fatigue, and for many women these can be disruptive.

Both States are planning outreach screening and counselling at the community level, women’s-health clinics, district-level well-women screening, and community outreach, besides referrals to district hospitals and government medical colleges. No doubt, this is a progressive measure which will also give legitimacy to the complaints of menopausal women, but the proof of any pudding is in the eating. How effective these policies are will be measured only during implementation. Among the critical points today is that the symptoms of menopause are not treated with adequate seriousness even by the medical community; so, adequate awareness generation among medical professionals and the beneficiaries and their families as well is a must.

For decades, India’s relationship with West Asia operated under a doctrine of deliberate ambiguity and even of some strategic distance. Delhi treated the “Middle East” primarily as an economic hinterland: a critical source of crude oil, a reliable destination for outbound labour, and a vital conduit for remittances. When regional crises flared, Indian foreign policy defaulted to hedging, balancing relations between competing power centres such as Riyadh, Tehran, Tel Aviv, and Abu Dhabi without tying itself to the security obligations of any single capital. Of late, we called that approach “multi-alignment”.

What worked until now

But while India was careful to be friendly to all, it was not too friendly to any, in an effort not to offend any of the various capitals in the mix. The logic was clear: there was much to be gained from all parties in what was widely seen to be a likely West Asian economic renaissance. The region was seen through a macroeconomic vision that highlighted its convenient geographic features, its immense natural resources of oil and gas, massive capital accumulation, and its receptivity to imported labour and skills, of which India has a surplus. In this framing, the global economic centre of gravity was seen as inexorably shifting away from an aging, debt-burdened West toward a highly dynamic Asia, positioning West Asia as the ultimate maritime and terrestrial bridge between a declining West and a rising East.

This defensive and essentially transactional posture served India well in an era when the United States stood as the undisputed guarantor of West Asian security, keeping sea lines of communication open and maintaining regional stability. However, the geopolitical bedrock of West Asia is undergoing a violent structural shift. As Washington recalibrates its global commitments and retreats into an unpredictable “selective engagement” posture, a profound security vacuum has emerged, sparking a scramble among regional states for durable security guarantees. Here, has India been caught napping, continuing a business-as-usual approach that risks early obsolescence?

West Asian capitals no longer view distancing, whether called non-alignment or multi-alignment, as a virtue. They are actively seeking alternative, dependable security partners who can offer more than diplomatic platitudes and routine economic cooperation. This structural reality was highlighted by the signing of the Mecca Joint Defence Agreement, bringing together Saudi Arabia, Türkiye, and Pakistan into a collective defence arrangement. While framed as a defensive effort to manage shared



Shashi Tharoor

Fourth-term Member of Parliament (Congress) for Thiruvananthapuram, who served nearly three decades at the United Nations, where he rose to the position of Under Secretary-General. He has also been a Minister of State for External Affairs in the Government of India and is the bestselling author, of 29 books, including ‘Pax Indica: India and the World of the 21st century’. He currently chairs the Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs

A changing West Asia requires a more assertive Indian role in pursuing real, hard-power security partnerships

vulnerabilities, the pact signals a broader security realignment. By linking Gulf capital with Turkish defence technology and Pakistani military manpower and skill, the agreement creates a powerful new security architecture right at India’s western maritime doorstep.

A clear signal of change

For New Delhi, the Mecca Agreement is not an isolated diplomatic transaction; it is a clear structural signal that West Asia’s security framework is being fundamentally rewritten, often by actors whose strategic interests directly run counter to India’s own long-term objectives. While India’s strategic silence on this development is understandable, it still begs the question: what next? The growing influence of external powers and hostile regional pacts directly threatens India’s trade routes, energy security, and the welfare of millions of Indian citizens living in the Gulf. Is India going to build its own partnerships, or become irrelevant to the region’s security?

If India continues to rely on legacy diplomatic processes and transactional commerce, it risks being marginalised in a region essential to its national survival. The challenges are formidable. The eruption of hostilities involving Iran demonstrated that modern, highly integrated economic infrastructure remains profoundly fragile when subjected to grey-zone, asymmetric warfare. State-of-the-art port facilities, energy networks, and logistics corridors proved highly vulnerable to low-cost drones, showing that capital-intensive infrastructure cannot fully compensate for localised security vacuums. Hyper-secure economic enclaves will remain perpetually exposed to the spillover effects of surrounding instability in the region. Since the modern Gulf model relies heavily on foreign corporations and expatriate labour, regional stability is intimately tied to global perception. If security risks cross a certain psychological threshold, the talent and capital that flowed in seamlessly can exit just as rapidly. And when narrow naval chokepoints or overland trade routes face active disruption, global supply chains inevitably stall, revealing that these ambitious trade corridors are only as strong as their most unstable geographic link.

Against this critical background, the assumption that trade ties and diaspora diplomacy alone can preserve Indian influence is rapidly unravelling. A region grappling with maritime threats in the Red Sea, drone strikes on critical infrastructure, involvement in conflicts in Iran, Yemen, Sudan, the Strait of Hormuz and now the Bab el-Mandab, requires partners capable of providing tangible security assets.

West Asian powers are hungry for hard-power options such as naval patrols, intelligence sharing, defence-industrial collaboration, and credible counter-terrorism capabilities. If India Delhi-dallies over stepping into such a role, others will fill the void, as Türkiye has already demonstrated in Mecca.

The hard moves India must make

To protect its strategic space, New Delhi must contemplate a decisive doctrine change, evolving from a passive beneficiary of regional stability into an active guarantor of it. This requires moving beyond high-level bilateral visits and economic summits to actively project hard power into the western Indian Ocean and the broader West Asian region. India’s immediate focus must be the rapid expansion of naval and maritime security partnerships across key choke points, including the Strait of Hormuz, the Gulf of Oman and the Gulf of Aden, the waters off the Somali coast and the Bab-el-Mandeb. By embedding its naval footprint more deeply through joint maritime patrols, permanent logistics access arrangements, and interoperable surveillance networks with friendly Gulf states, India can establish itself as a, if not the, premier net security provider in its immediate neighbourhood.

Furthermore, India must leverage its growing defence manufacturing ecosystem to offer West Asian states a reliable alternative for hardware and technology. Collaborative defence ventures, joint military exercises with real operational teeth, and deep intelligence-sharing mechanisms must replace mere procurement discussions. Developing robust bilateral and “minilateral” security frameworks with partners such as the United Arab Emirates or Israel, and separately even with Saudi Arabia, will allow Delhi to build a counterweight against hostile axes without succumbing to rigid Cold-War style alliances. The goal is not to entangle India in foreign quagmires, but to build a strategic deterrence web that safeguards Indian interests and reassures regional allies.

The era of passive presence in West Asia has reached its natural end. The Mecca Agreement serves as a stark reminder that regional security arrangements will coalesce with or without Indian participation. If Delhi wishes to secure its economic destiny, safeguard its energy arteries, and claim its rightful place as a leading global power, it must act with urgency and ambition. Moving decisively beyond routine diplomatic engagement to construct real, hard-power security partnerships in West Asia is no longer just a strategic choice for India. It is an imperative for its national security.

A BIT of a reset, with a wider debate

It has been widely reported that India is revising its model bilateral investment treaty (BIT) and that the revised text will soon be placed before the Union cabinet. The seeds of this were sown when Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman said in the Union Budget speech in 2025, that India was considering revamping its 2015 Model BIT. The treaty was adopted as part of a broader appraisal process launched after several foreign investors sued India for BIT breaches. The two key outcomes of this appraisal were the unilateral termination of BITs and the adoption of a new model BIT as the basis to launch new negotiations.

A model that is out of balance

In the last decade or so, India has managed to conclude only a handful of BITs based on its 2015 model. This reveals the many limitations of the 2015 model, which many scholars, including this writer, have repeatedly pointed out. If investment treaties aim to balance the two competing objectives of investment protection (one end of the spectrum) and the state’s right to regulate (the other end), the Indian model BIT tilts heavily towards the latter. This creates doubts among countries that export capital to India about the legal protection afforded to their investments. These doubts are exacerbated by high regulatory risks, not-so-well-developed governance models, and an agonisingly tardy judicial system. As these concerns have grown louder, India has rightly decided to revisit the model, apparently with the objective of pulling the pendulum back towards the centre.

Any process of review of BITs has two core components. The first is on what substantive and procedural changes need to be made to the law; and the second is about what processes need to be followed to ensure the robustness of the outcome. The first aspect has attracted considerable attention, with experts pointing out



Prabhash Ranjan

Professor and Vice Dean (Research), Jindal Global Law School, and was part of the team of experts assembled by the Law Commission of India to study the 2015 draft model bilateral investment treaty (BIT)

Revising India’s bilateral investment treaty (BIT) requires consultation and stronger democratic accountability

the necessary legal reforms, such as making it easier for foreign investors to use international arbitration for treaty claims, enhancing the substantive protections for foreign investment, and having more investment facilitation measures. However, the second issue has not been deliberated much.

Concerns about democratic deficit

Since international economic treaties, including those on foreign investment, have a conspicuous impact on citizens, it brings into play the all-affected principle in democracy. In other words, whether those affected by, say, an investment treaty should have a right to participate in decision-making. If those affected are not able to participate effectively in decision-making, say, through their elected representatives or other civil society organisations, it raises concerns about ‘democratic deficit’ in the treaty-making process. Originating in debates in Europe, ‘democratic deficit’ refers to the insufficient oversight of technocrats and bureaucracies, or the executive in general, including the political executive, who negotiate and evolve treaty frameworks behind closed doors. The lack of oversight may take many forms, such as a lack of or inadequate parliamentary supervision of the treaty-making process, and an absence of an external consultative process with other stakeholders, including subject-matter experts and civil society organisations.

To overcome the charge of ‘democratic deficit’, many countries, such as the United Kingdom and Australia, mandatorily place the text of the negotiated treaty before ratification on the floor of the Parliament, enabling it to express its views. Specifically, in the context of model BITs, Norway held two rounds of public consultations – in 2008 and 2015 – on an updated draft. Likewise, Colombia released its model BIT for public

consultation. India, too, in March 2015, circulated its draft 2015 model BIT for public comment. This provided an opportunity for the Law Commission of India (LCI) to assemble a team of experts to study the draft model BIT. The LCI, in its 260th report, made recommendations on how to improve the draft model BIT. India finally adopted the revised version in December 2015, though not all of the LCI’s recommended changes were reflected in it.

Have a consultative process

Presumably, the government must have already undertaken widespread internal consultations, i.e., intra-governmental deliberations on the model BIT. As regards external consultation, the following may be considered. First, form a core team of experts, external to the government, who have demonstrated proficiency in international investment law or foreign investment, and engage with them. This would ideally include international lawyers and economists drawn from universities, research institutions and think tanks. This core team could act as the sounding board for the government. Second, invite industry bodies, arbitrators, law firms, and other civil society organisations to offer their views on the model BIT.

Following these first two steps, the third step will be to prepare a draft and place it in the public domain, inviting comments from the public at large, as done in March 2015. In the fourth step, or simultaneously, the draft model BIT should be placed on the floor of Parliament for discussion. The relevant department-related parliamentary committees can also be roped in for the same. Most notably, this consultative process should not be carried out merely as a box-ticking exercise, but as a meaningful activity that upholds the spirit of participatory democracy, which would necessarily include engagement with dissenting views.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Crisis of confidence

India cannot call itself a young nation with confidence if its young people are forced to fight for basic opportunities. They want quality education, employment, entrepreneurship, economic independence and dignity. These are not unreasonable demands. The government must ask a fundamental question: why are students losing confidence in the existing education system? The government must

understand that every frustrated student on the street represents a failure somewhere in the system – whether in education, employment, administration or opportunity. But Gen Z must understand something equally important: democracy requires responsibilities as well as rights. Protests must be peaceful. The government must therefore undertake a ruthless review of Ministries and public institutions

where performance is inadequate. Non-performance must have consequences. Corruption must have consequences. Deliberate obstruction of reforms must have consequences. **Richard Hay,** Kochi, Keralam
Calling Gen Z apolitical may overlook the issues that genuinely concern them. Young people in India engage actively with questions of

unemployment, education, climate change and social justice, even if they remain distant from conventional politics. The challenge, therefore, is not merely to increase political participation but to make democratic spaces more accessible and meaningful to young citizens. Gen Z in India may not be apolitical; it may simply be politically disenchanting. Have we considered this? **Sodsi Raj,** Dhenkanal, Odisha

New Secretariat in Chennai
The report, “New Secretariat to come up in Chennai at ₹1,200 crore: Vijay” (Front page, September 4), has highlighted three possible sites. Having been involved in the site-selection process in 2003 as tahsildar, Mylapore-Triplicane taluk, I would like to suggest the Madras Race Course as another option. Several sites, including the Government Data Centre, Anna University Campus,

Directorate of Technical Education, Highways Research Station and Anna University’s Taramani Campus, were surveyed at the time. The Madras Race Course could be ideal, given its accessibility, scope for wider road approaches, suitability for VIP visits and convenient access for the public. **S. Dharmarajan,** Chennai
Letters emailed to letters@thehindu.co.in must carry the postal address.

GROUND ZERO



The government middle school in Hirapur, Sehore district, Madhya Pradesh. The school is located in a dilapidated building. It is in the same premises as the village panchayat office and a community centre ground. MEHUL MALPANI

Missing: boundary walls, bathrooms, blackboards

Across north and central India, government school education, especially in rural areas, is a challenge, both in terms of the number of teachers in every school and the state of the building that houses children. Reporters from four States track the state of school education. **Amarnath Tewary, Ashna Butani, Mayank Kumar, and Mehul Malpani** examine teaching quality and infrastructural support

On August 10, Abhijeet Dipke, founder of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP), said in a video that since Independence, no government has been able to provide students in rural areas with the same facilities as those available to students in urban areas. He pledged to begin checking schools in the district from which he hails, Hingoli in Maharashtra, and request sarpanchs to improve the situation.

“We have constructed a new Parliament and a new residence for the Prime Minister. Why, then, are we not able to construct new schools in our villages? Do we not consider the children of farmers and labourers as the future of our country,” he asked.

Since August 15, the CJP’s ‘School thik karo (reform schools)’ campaign has shone a spotlight on the condition of schools across States, with issues ranging from broken roofs to a lack of washrooms and drinking water. It asked locals to participate in a three-step audit of schools: ‘download a checklist, conduct the audit, and submit and tag us’. The checklist includes questions about whether the school has drinking water, boundary walls, wash rooms, and midday meals.

Bihar

At Dumri Kewat Tola primary school, in Muzaffarpur district in north Bihar, the plaster sometimes falls in the corridor outside the two classrooms. “We dread walking on this veranda,” says one teacher.

All the 119 students crowd into the pink building, which was painted six months ago but is already peeling. They share space with two goats, which play on the corridor, and occasionally wander in to be petted. Under the crumbling roof of the corridor stand two motorcycles – they belong to the teachers.

“The school was established in 1982, but there is no boundary wall, no wash room, no sports ground, and no space to store the midday meal supplies,” says the headmaster, Sanju Kumar. He travels 15 kilometres daily, one way, to reach the village. The six teachers of the school use the neighbours’ bathrooms, they say, but the children must simply go in the open, or not at all. The school has no space to build, say the teachers.

At the middle school, a kilometre away, at Budhnagra Jagannath Malikana Tola, established in 2002, there are 10 teachers and 283 students. The principal, Umesh Ram, is sad that the school has only two rooms. Students of Class 8 sit on the veranda, and those of Classes 1 and 2 under a tree behind the classrooms.

The teachers complain about space constraints and the fact that the area floods in the rains. The students say their midday meal is tasteless. “Sometimes there are insects in it. We want our food to be better,” says one student.

The district education officer says he has written to his superiors in Bihar’s Education Department about the schools’ demands.

In the adjoining Vaishali district, the primary school at Mirpur Pathad Rajdeo Rai Ka Tola does not even have a building of its own. It runs in a community centre, established in 2014.

The school, from Classes 1 to 5, runs in a single

The school has no playground, no wash room, no kitchen shed, nothing at all

UDAY KUMAR
Teacher, Bihar

room, which is also stuffed with rows of department almirahs and midday meal utensils, tables, and broken chairs. The students sit on new benches. There are 91 students and three teachers, including the headmaster, Vinod Kumar.

“The school has no playground, no wash room, no kitchen shed, nothing at all,” says Uday Kumar, a teacher who travels about 40 km every day to reach the school by motorcycle.

“You can imagine the difficulties we face here every day. When more students come to school than the space allows, they have to sit under a huge banyan tree nearby to study,” says Kumar.

The Block Education Department of Rajaparak could not be reached. On its department website, the Bihar government reads, “Education is the pillar upon which the fate of a country depends.”

Rajasthan

In Unchki village in Rajasthan’s Deeg district, there is no public road to the Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya, which is blocked by a graveyard on one side and high boundary walls on the other. Locals say students have no option but to walk through the graveyard. From there, they traverse a thin, muddy path, surrounded by overgrown plants and shrubs, to go to school. A student of Class 3 says, “*Bach bach ke aana padhta hai. Keechar bohut hai* (We have to come cautiously; it is very muddy).”

Students say corridors are their classrooms. One student says, “The teacher teaches both Class 4 and 5 together.” This is either because there are not enough rooms in the building to accommodate all of them or no electricity. The district falls under the National Capital Region and is only 165 km from Delhi.

“My children come home during the middle of the day and then go back to school,” explains Sakira Khan, a mother of two children who study in this school. This is because there are no wash rooms. Behind the school there are two brick structures with overgrown shrubs. They open onto the fields and have no doors. In Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya in Amrooka village in the same district, again students say they sit on a corridor outside the classroom which does not have electricity. There are 85 students enrolled in the school. The Rajkiya Prathamik Vidyalaya, in Bas Bolkheda village in Deeg, is located on a hill and caters to students from the neighbourhood. As they leave, students say they have had fun, running around the classroom. They say there are two teachers; neither had come that day. A temporary teacher assigned from another school visits them after finishing his day at the school where he is posted.

The teachers in all the three schools say they have received orders from their supervisors not to speak to the media. One says, on the condition of anonymity, “We keep writing to the district authorities about the shortage of classrooms, but they say they do not have the budget.”

There is one empty teaching post in one of the schools. “We are forced to manage,” explains another teacher. “We all take turns to teach students from another class.”

The teachers also admit that many students

do not attend class because of infrastructural issues. While there is no permanent principal, a nodal officer in each block frequently visits the school, serving as the principal. In all three schools, the teachers say 50-60% of the total enrolled students come to school daily.

Locals sitting under a tree near the school say children do not learn much in government schools compared to private schools. Aas Mohammad, whose granddaughter skipped school for the day, says, “It is not possible to send all my grandchildren to private schools. They may have all the facilities, but they cost some ₹18,000 a year.”

Locals also allege that governments do not pay attention to their requests because they live in predominantly Muslim areas.

District Magistrate Mayank Manish says if Education Department officials receive complaints from schools, they act on them quickly. “The government is focused on education. It is trying to increase or convert funds wherever possible. Teachers’ vacancies are filled regularly, and online materials are made available in case of a shortage of teachers,” he says. On specific concerns such as the lack of toilets and pathways to schools, he says officials will look into the matter.

Uttar Pradesh

Aworried Digvijay Narayan (name changed), 44, asks his wife which non-essential expenses they can cut to reduce their monthly spending.

Narayan, who lives in an urban settlement near Dayal Chauraha in Gomti Nagar, Lucknow, is a cab driver. He is considering moving his daughter, Payal Gautam (name changed), 11, from the Government Primary School Gwari in Vikas Khand in Lucknow to a private school after she suffered a prolonged illness due to a urinary tract infection. “We believe the dirty wash room at the government school caused the infection. She had symptoms for more than 10 days,” he says.

He is anxious about arranging an additional ₹1,000 per month for the move. “My son goes to a private school; now both will go together. I will ask the management to give me some concession,” he says.

Payal says she travels over a kilometre by foot to go to school every day. Drinking water, she says, comes “in fits and starts.” About the wash room, she says she will never use it again. “The water facilities in the wash room are dysfunctional at times, so we have to arrange for water from the houses nearby.”

Narayan feels the dismal infrastructure also impacts productivity. “A peaceful atmosphere, like what you find in a private school, will help the student focus on their studies,” he says.

Madhya Pradesh

Around 1 p.m., five teachers sit in two classrooms at the government middle school in Hirapur village of Madhya Pradesh’s Sehore district, about 40 km from the State capital, Bhopal. Students are absent; they have not returned to classes after the festival of Raksha Bandhan.

The school is located in a dilapidated building. It is in the same premises as the village panchayat office and a community centre ground. The four-room school, which includes a small principal’s office, has only 22 students enrolled across eight classes. While teachers have chairs and tables, there are no benches for students. The classrooms have mats on the floor, dim lighting, and broken almirahs. While one classroom does not have fans, the other two have fans that are out of order. The walls and the roofs have rainwater seeping through during the monsoon.

Next to the school building is a small pit filled with dirty water covered by green moss and surrounded by bushes. The community centre ground is filled with cattle dung. Stray dogs roam

around. There are two wash room complexes on the opposite sides of the ground – one for the staff and the other for students. However, in the students’ complex, only one of the two wash rooms is functional, forcing female and male students to use the same toilet.

The school in-charge, Mahendra Singh Sisodia, says students from eight classes are being accommodated in three classrooms after the primary school building on the same premises was abandoned about six months ago because of its poor condition.

Most of the 22 students at the school are from marginalised communities, he says. “Other dominant communities in the village send their children to private schools, so this school does not get much attention,” he says. Since the premises do not have a gate, some people also use the ground for drinking at night, he adds.

A small room is used as the kitchen to prepare the midday meal for the children. Sisodia says that the self-help group designated to prepare the meal stopped its services about three months ago. “I have informed Education Department officials at the district level and they have instructed me to make arrangements for now. So, I have been buying ration for the school. Hopefully the money will be reimbursed soon,” he says, adding that the school also does not have drinking water supply and the students bring bottles from home.

The school falls under the Ichhawar Assembly segment, the constituency of the State Revenue Minister, Karan Singh Verma.

About 20 km from Hirapur is Sarvar village in Bhopal’s rural outskirts. The government middle school here appears clean and well maintained. There is a boundary wall and a gate, and the campus has plants. However, a conversation with the students reveals a different story. The classrooms don’t have an electricity connection and many do not have fans or lights. The switchboards have been removed and the wires taped shut.

A Class 8 student says, “Since there is no light in the classrooms, it is difficult to study here, especially during the monsoon when we have to shut the windows. The summer heat is intolerable. While I like my school and teachers, this is one thing that we all want fixed at the earliest.”

The school has a strength of 104 students. All the three teachers for Classes 6-8 are on leave, while the principal, Suresh Malviya, is at an official training exercise. There are only two teachers of the primary classes present.

Over the phone, Malviya says that the school building has been in poor condition for about five years. The electricity connection had to be cut since water was leaking through the ceiling and there was risk of it reaching the wires, he says.

“We have been sending annual proposals for repairs for five years but no one has taken cognisance of it. The school gets ₹25,000 annually for miscellaneous works. It’s not enough to repair the building. The money is utilised for hiring a worker once a month to clean the wash rooms,” Malviya says.

Another teacher says, “The floor, the boundary wall, and the gate – or anything that appears in a good condition – was built by the village panchayat after a school alumnus became its head a few years ago. There is barely any attention on such matters from the department.”

Students complain of poor quality of food and say that many prefer to bring food from home. “The dal is watery and the rotis are often burnt or not properly cooked,” says a Class 7 student.

At both schools, the worried staff asked if this was an inspection by the CJP or whether permission had been obtained from senior officials.

An official at the School Education Department highlights a gap in the government’s approach towards different kinds of schools in the State. “Over the past few years, the focus has been on flagship institutions like Sandipani (earlier known as CM Rise) Schools and Excellence schools, so small rural schools, which were already not in a very good condition, have been struggling even for basic infrastructure.”

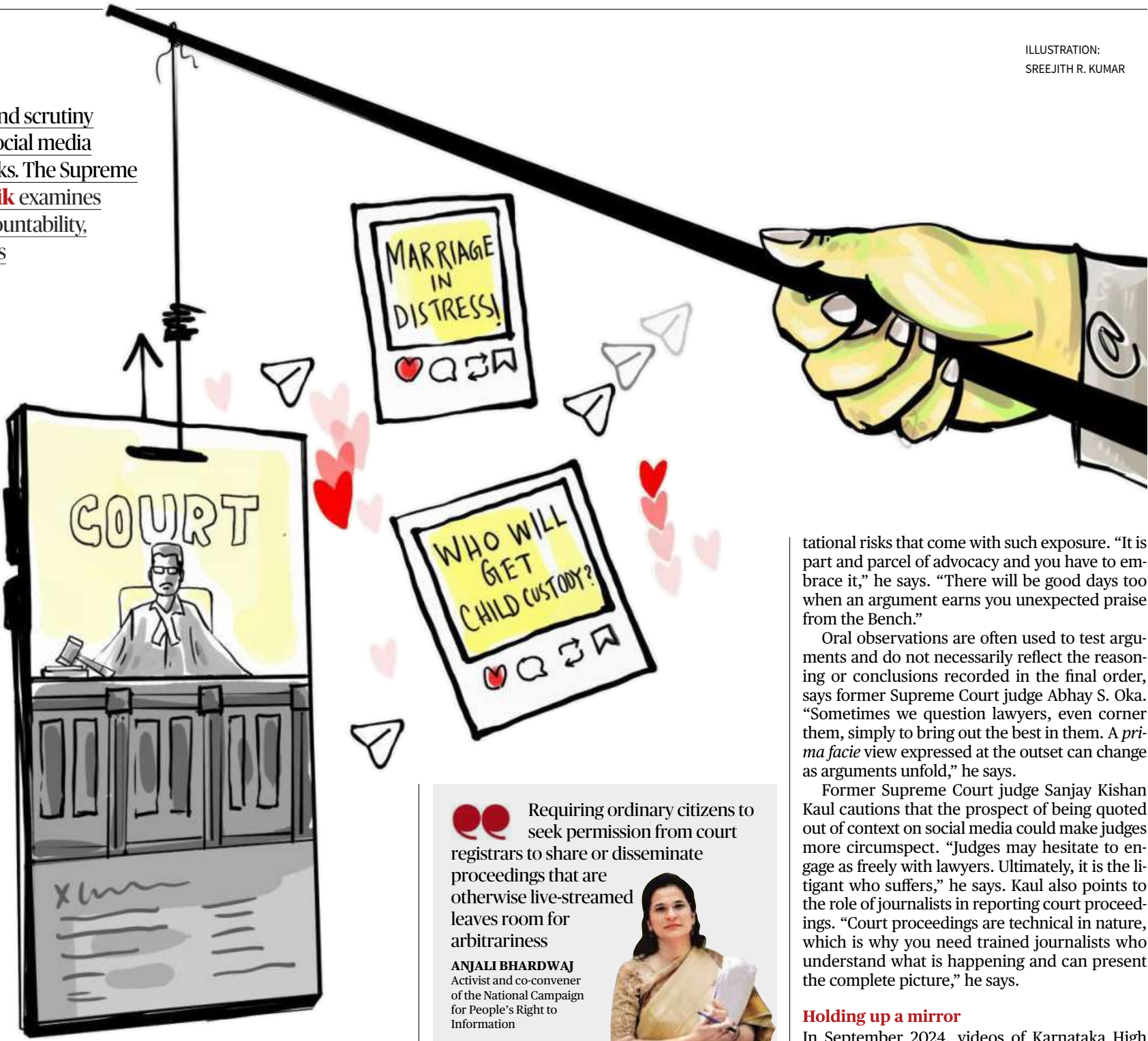
amarnath.tewary@thehindu.co.in; ashna.butani@thehindu.co.in; mayank.kumar@thehindu.co.in; mehul.malpani@thehindu.co.in

DELHI

Live-streaming and virtual hearings have brought transparency and scrutiny to courtrooms. But footage is often snipped and uploaded onto social media platforms, sometimes stripped of context and repackaged for clicks. The Supreme Court has moved to restrict their circulation. **Aaratrika Bhaumik** examines what the interim order could mean for public access, judicial accountability, and the youth, which is accustomed to consuming bite-sized news

Courtroom
dramas,
clipped
and shared

ILLUSTRATION:
SREEJITH R. KUMAR



From her room in a town in Assam, Tanisha Som, 24, would spend hours watching courtrooms, hundreds of kilometres away, come to life on her screen. She would watch women lawyers command the courtroom, threading their arguments through a thicket of questions from the Bench, pressing an argument here and conceding there, until even the most sceptical judges began to come around. At the time, becoming a lawyer seemed a dream. She had little sense of what went on behind the soaring columns and heavy wooden doors of an institution that seemed built as much to inspire awe as to keep outsiders out.

Then in 2022, the Supreme Court began live-streaming proceedings before its Constitutional Benches. These Benches comprise five or more judges deciding substantial questions concerning the interpretation of the Constitution.

“Until then, much of what I knew about courtrooms came from Bollywood movies. Live-streamed proceedings and courtroom clips gave me a window into how courts actually function. For the first time, I could picture myself on the other side of the screen – inside one of those courtrooms, in a black robe,” she says.

Nearly three years ago, Som made it to her dream law school. Despite the gruelling schedule of a national law university, court proceedings remained a part of her day. She would sit through Constitution Bench hearings on YouTube or stumble upon courtroom clips on Instagram, wedged between memes and viral dance trends.

“These video clips instilled in me a passion for advocacy and helped me understand courcraft. It is not something you can really learn within the four walls of a classroom,” she says.

But the clips that gave Som an early glimpse into the profession are now at the centre of a larger debate: while they have brought transparency and scrutiny to courtrooms, exchanges between judges and lawyers can also be clipped out of context and circulated for sensationalism.

Harshita Grover, a journalist, recently moved the Supreme Court asking for restrictions on circulation of courtroom clips on digital platforms. She pointed out that many were distorted and stripped of context.

On July 24, the Supreme Court, in an interim order, barred the use and circulation of audio and video clips of judicial proceedings on social media and other digital platforms without prior permission from court registrars.

A Bench led by Chief Justice of India (CJI) Surya Kant said “isolated excerpts” risked “trivialising” the administration of justice. The next hearing of the case is scheduled for September 18.

The court later clarified that “recognised news outlets” could continue reporting on proceedings, but could not “utilise” audio or video clips. However, it did not define the term “recognised news outlets”, leaving some confusion among those who report on court proceedings, especially independent journalists. While it considers a broader protocol, the court has added other stakeholders to the proceedings. These include High Courts and social media intermediaries, including Meta, LinkedIn, and X Corp.

The unfettered access Som enjoyed was elusive when Swapnil Tripathi, 29, was a law student nearly eight years ago. While interning with a Supreme Court lawyer, he spent weeks working on a case of constitutional importance, only to miss the hearing because interns were allowed inside the court only on certain days to prevent overcrowding.

“I was very disheartened. I had worked closely on the case and wanted to see how the arguments played out,” he recalls. But conversations with litigants soon made him realise that the institutional barriers to accessing courtrooms were not limited to law students. “Litigants would travel to Delhi from remote corners of the country, often for cases that could alter the course of their lives. Yet, many could not even enter the courtroom because of overcrowding,” he says.

Tripathi soon moved the Supreme Court seeking live-streaming of cases of constitutional importance. In September 2018, his petition culminated in a landmark ruling recognising live-streaming as part of the right to access justice under Article 21 of the Constitution. Underlining that “sunlight is the best disinfectant”, Justice D.Y. Chandrachud reasoned that the public’s right to know how justice is administered is integral to a functioning democracy.

Virtual hearing links are often shared indiscriminately beyond litigants and lawyers. So even when High Courts pause live-streaming for sensitive cases, people logged into the virtual hearing can record the proceedings

SWAPNIL TRIPATHI
Head of Charkha
(Centre for Constitutional Law)
at the Vidhi Centre
for Legal Policy, a think tank



In March 2026, Law Minister Arjun Ram Meghwal told the Lok Sabha that live-streaming was operational in 11 High Courts. The Supreme Court’s official YouTube channel has now amassed over 2.67 lakh subscribers, with major Constitution Bench proceedings available to anyone with a screen and an Internet connection. A video of its *suo motu* hearing in the R.G. Kar rape-murder case, uploaded in September 2024, has been viewed nearly 48,000 times – an audience that could never have squeezed into a physical courtroom. This is one of the rare instances when a rape case was live-streamed on the apex court’s YouTube channel.

Although the Supreme Court has 17 functioning courtrooms, it largely live-streams only Constitution Bench hearings, which are held intermittently. In contrast, High Courts such as Gujarat, Karnataka, and Calcutta live-stream proceedings daily from a majority of their courtrooms. Gujarat became the first High Court to formally go live on YouTube in July 2021 and its channel now has nearly 1.97 lakh subscribers.

Live streams are not the only source of courtroom footage online. The Supreme Court and High Courts also allow lawyers and litigants to join hearings virtually through platforms such as Cisco Webex, with links often made available through daily cause lists. Clips from these proceedings, too, have found their way onto social media, including from sensitive matters involving sexual offences, matrimonial disputes, and child custody.

Tripathi, who now heads Charkha (Centre for Constitutional Law) at the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, a think tank, says the 2018 judgment anticipated some of the concerns being flagged today. “Safeguards were built in from the beginning,” he says, pointing out that matrimonial and sexual assault cases and proceedings involving children and juveniles were excluded from live-streaming. The Supreme Court e-Committee’s Model Rules released in 2021, he notes, also prohibit unauthorised dissemination and use of courtroom footage for commercial, promotional, or advertising purposes.

Requiring ordinary citizens to seek permission from court registrars to share or disseminate proceedings that are otherwise live-streamed leaves room for arbitrariness

ANJALI BHARDWAJ
Activist and co-convenor
of the National Campaign
for People’s Right to
Information



Court proceedings are technical in nature, which is why you need trained journalists who understand what is happening and can present the complete picture

SANJAY KISHAN KAUL
Former Supreme Court Judge



“However, what we are seeing now is that virtual hearing links are often shared indiscriminately beyond litigants and lawyers,” he says.

“So even when High Courts pause live-streaming for sensitive cases, people logged into the virtual hearing can record the proceedings and put them on social media despite rules prohibiting unauthorised recording,” he adds.

Anjali Bhardwaj, activist and co-convenor of the National Campaign for People’s Right to Information, says the interim order marks a shift towards a permission regime. “Requiring ordinary citizens to seek permission from court registrars to share or disseminate proceedings that are otherwise live-streamed leaves room for arbitrariness,” she says. “There is no clarity on how permission is to be sought, the grounds for granting or denying it, or the recourse available if it is refused.” Acknowledging the risk of clips being taken out of context, Bhardwaj suggests that a better safeguard could be to expand live-streaming and archiving of proceedings on authorised platforms instead of restricting their circulation. “A complete, official record acts as a deterrent and allows manipulated clips to be readily exposed.”

A courtroom in your feed

A netizen may now swipe past holiday photos, influencer reels, and courtroom scenes with the same detached ease. Controversial matrimonial cases can draw over 1 lakh views. Sometimes, lawyers use a judge’s remark to leverage their social media following.

In July 2026, the Bar Council of India issued a circular prohibiting reels and promotional content from court premises. It also directed State Bar Councils to designate social media ethics nodal officers to deal with complaints and lawyers to submit a signed undertaking at the time of enrolment pledging to maintain professional conduct on social media.

“Matrimonial and custody cases generally draw the most attention on social media,” says Ravitosh Dubey, founder of legal news portal *LawChakra*. “Someone going through a divorce, for instance, would be curious to see how courts approach such cases, the questions judges ask, and how the process unfolds,” he says.

Since the interim order, *LawChakra* has largely shifted to explanatory videos without courtroom footage. Clips that accurately represent court proceedings should not be restricted, Dubey says. At *LawChakra*, edits were limited to trimming pauses and removing litigants’ personal details. “I have consciously refrained from publishing heated exchanges between the Bench and the Bar when, viewed in isolation, they could misrepresent what transpired in court.”

The proliferation of courtroom clips has also brought lawyers under scrutiny. They are increasingly aware that their clients may be watching. “You cannot simply seek unnecessary adjournments,” says Supreme Court advocate Lavkesh Bhambhani. “To earn your fee, you have to satisfy the client that you have done justice to their case.”

Bhambhani, however, is unfazed by the reputational risks that come with such exposure. “It is part and parcel of advocacy and you have to embrace it,” he says. “There will be good days too when an argument earns you unexpected praise from the Bench.”

Former Supreme Court judge Sanjay Kishan Kaul cautions that the prospect of being quoted out of context on social media could make judges more circumspect. “Judges may hesitate to engage as freely with lawyers. Ultimately, it is the litigant who suffers,” he says. Kaul also points to the role of journalists in reporting court proceedings. “Court proceedings are technical in nature, which is why you need trained journalists who understand what is happening and can present the complete picture,” he says.

Holding up a mirror

In September 2024, videos of Karnataka High Court judge Justice Vedavyasachar Srishananda sparked furore online. He was seen in one video referring to a Muslim-dominated locality in west Bengaluru as “Pakistan” and making a sexist remark to a woman lawyer in another.

Within days, a Supreme Court Bench led by then CJI D.Y. Chandrachud took *suo motu* cognisance, cautioning judges against making “casual observations” reflecting communal bias or misogyny. The judge later apologised and the proceedings were closed. More recently, CJI Kant’s reported reference to “cockroaches” during a hearing on fake law degrees drew widespread criticism and spawned the Cockroach Janta Party, which went on to spearhead protests against examination paper leaks. CJI Kant later said his remarks had been “misquoted” by the media.

Oral observations by judges are crucial to report despite having no binding value, says Manu Sebastian, managing editor of legal news portal *LiveLaw*. “They offer an insight into judicial thinking and hold a mirror to the institution. The response should be introspection, not clamping down on public scrutiny or reportage,” he says.

He points to the Supreme Court’s 2021 ruling in *Chief Election Commissioner vs M.R. Vijayabhaskar*, which protected the reporting of oral remarks and stressed the role of public scrutiny in ensuring institutional accountability.

Sebastian adds that the exemption for “recognised news outlets” could favour established media organisations over citizen journalists and smaller newsrooms. He sees little justification for permitting written accounts of courtroom exchanges while prohibiting video clips that faithfully reproduce them.

“AI-generated or doctored videos should be prohibited. But faithful reporting, regardless of the medium, should be permitted,” he says.

The risk of misreporting, Justice Oka notes, predates the social media age. “I remember being misquoted by a trainee print journalist when I was a Bombay High Court judge,” he says.

“Oral remarks can be misreported or sensationalised in newspaper reports too. But as long as judges confine themselves to the merits of the case, that should not deter them from speaking their minds,” he adds.

Pointing to a rapidly evolving media ecosystem, legal scholar Alok Prasanna Kumar says courts must adapt to changing news consumption habits. “Allowing an oral exchange to be reported in print while restricting its dissemination through video clips is at odds with how people consume news today,” he says. “It is a bit like trying to stop the wind from blowing.”

A March 2026 report by the Reuters Institute, which facilitates programmes to promote the practice and analysis of journalism, captures the shift. It states that people in the 18 to 24 age group citing social media as their main source of news rose from 21% in 2015 to 39% in 2025, overtaking news websites and apps. The report also describes young audiences as increasingly “social-first”, with much of their news consumption incidental rather than intentional.

Any new restrictions should follow wide-ranging consultation, says former Supreme Court judge Madan B. Lokur. “A unilateral decision is never welcome. Any institutional reform should involve all High Courts and stakeholders.”

Som, now in her final months of law school, will soon don the black robes she once dreamt of. But she remains wary of depending on traditional media to tell her what happens inside a courtroom. “The judiciary wields enormous power over our lives. I don’t want a sanitised version of how that power is exercised,” she says.

“I would rather see what happened and decide for myself.”

aaratrika.bhaumik@thehindu.co.in



Martial arts other than Kalaripayattu, Karate and Kung Fu are gaining acceptance in Keralam. **Tiki Rajwi** meets some of the trainers and practitioners of combat sports to understand the changing trends

Art of fighting

There is a moment in the 2023 Marko Zaror-starrer Chilean martial arts flick *The Fist of the Condor* (*El puño del condor*) where the antagonist, played by Eyal Meyer, leaps high in the thick of a fight, twists his outstretched body mid-flight and drops into a neat *Ashwa Vadivu*. Kalaripayattu practitioners will quickly identify the ‘horse stance’ as something singular to their art. But Chile in Andean South America is scarcely a place one instantly associates with the move.

“I had received a phone call from Marko, saying they were making a new movie and wanted to introduce different martial arts and techniques to the project. He had heard about me as an actor and my relationship with Kalaripayattu. He told me that we should first rehearse to see if this martial art would work for the movie. I immediately said, ‘Sure, let’s go for it,’” Meyer, who first came into contact with the martial art in 2006 while studying acting and theatre at the University of Chile, told *The Hindu* in a recent e-mail interview. Today, the actor runs Mauna Kalari in Santiago, the Chilean capital.

Back at home

While Kalaripayattu has been making ripples across the globe, back home in Keralam, its birthplace, a different kind of revolution is taking place on the local martial arts scene.

In State capital Thiruvananthapuram, 19-year-old Muhammed Aiman S. plans to launch a rigorous three-month preparation soon for Sanda, a Chinese full-contact sport, for the University Games in December. Before the advent of the internet and social media, very few people would have heard of this sport. Now Sanda is a staple of the thriving combat sport environment in Keralam along with Mixed Martial Arts (MMA), Muay Thai and Brazilian Jiu-Jitsu (BJJ). “I will have two training sessions daily— one each in the morning and evening. Sanda is a speed game, with punches, kicks and take-downs,” explains Aiman, who fights out of the Johnny Brothers Fight Club. A regular on the Muay Thai, Kickboxing and Sanda fight circuit, the psychology undergraduate began training in combat sports at a young age, amassing medals in the sub-junior and junior categories at the State and national levels. He recently won two of his three pro fights.

Win in Thailand

Ann Mary Philip from Edappally, Kochi, came to combat sports in her late thirties and went on to score a win in Thailand, the home of Muay Thai. Ann encountered kickboxing in 2018 while searching for a class for her son, Chris. Over the years, under the guidance of her coach Kiran V.S. of SpaRing combat sports gym, Ann evolved into Muay Thai, Boxing and its Olympic-sport tag, Taekwondo. At 42, she has now started training in BJJ. She first took part in a boxing tournament in 2024 when she was turning 40. “Forty is the age limit for amateur matches, but I had this great desire to experience boxing at least once. So my debut match was also my retirement match,” says Ann, who is a certified referee in Sambo and secretary general of the Sambo India Association.

People like Aiman and Ann represent the new breed of combat sports enthusiasts in the land of Kalaripayattu. Till a few years ago, the traditional martial arts (TMA) scene in Keralam was restricted to the big ‘Ks’— Karate, Kalaripayattu and Kung Fu— with Korean Taekwondo making a big entrance later on with its Olympic-sport tag. Today, MMA and Muay Thai clubs are all the rage in cities like Kochi, Thiruvananthapuram and Kozhikode and smaller towns, courtesy social media and YouTube. Unlike Karate classes of the 1980s

I don’t agree with the argument that Kalaripayattu is a relic art. It is such a wise and profound technology for the body and mind that I feel it is more current than one thinks

EYAL MEYER
Chilean actor



or 1990s, which were usually conducted twice or thrice a week in school auditoriums after class hours or atop the roof of somebody’s house, today it is all about snazzy-looking gyms with floor mats, protective gear, weight racks, boxing rings and a bevy of heavy bags lining the wall for punching and kicking.

“MMA is by far the most popular because of the Ultimate Fighting Championship,” says Joys Varghese, founder of Spartans Martial Arts and Fitness. A recognised referee in combat sport events such as MMA and Muay Thai, he himself had begun his martial arts journey with Karate. Joys says he switched to MMA because he wanted something practical and would work in a real-life scenario. “Youngsters today are not interested in spending time on the forms (set routines) in Karate and Kung-Fu. They want faster, workable results,” says Joys.

Combat sport gyms

In these new combat sport gyms across Keralam, the emphasis is on what works inside the octago-

nal MMA cage, the boxing ring or on the mat. The romance of Shaolin Temple-inspired spiritual quests through martial arts takes a back seat here. Television and social media platforms dedicated to combat sports have played a big role in encouraging the younger generation to try out and even pursue careers in these money-spinning sports.

MMA is precisely what the name suggests: an eclectic mixture of punches, kicks, knees, elbows, wrestling takedowns, locks and chokes. Muay Thai, the art of eight limbs, first caught the imagination of Indian youth through movies of Thai star Tony Jaa. Real-life fighters such as Saenchai, Buakaw Banchamek, Tawanchai and Rodtang Jitmuangnon, who enjoy a global following, are as familiar to combat sport buffs in today’s Keralam as the legendary figures of Kalaripayattu lore, Thacholi Othenan or Aromal Chekavar.

“Social media is the biggest reason for Muay Thai (or Thai Boxing) becoming so popular today,” says Binu Joseph, president of the Kerala State Muay Thai Association.

Binu had started training in Muay Thai in 2009 in Bengaluru. “I was already doing Karate and Kickboxing at the time. In 2014, we conducted the first Muay Thai refereeing seminar at Kalikavu in Malappuram district. Coaches from nine districts participated in it. Today, Muay Thai is one of two combat sports that are in high demand among youth in Keralam, the other being MMA,” he says. The association was also formed the same year. “Before social media, people here did not have much awareness about martial arts beyond Karate, Kalari or Kung Fu. That is not the case nowadays. They know about other sports that are effective and engaging,” he observes.

To train at clubs abroad

With the world becoming smaller, Keralites are also increasingly travelling to places such as Thailand and Japan to train at clubs there. Binu himself has been to Thailand twice. Ann went to Thailand in 2024 to attend a camp. “They have fight nights every week. I registered, and I got a Muay Thai bout at the Bangla stadium which I won in the minus-50 category,” says Ann.

Keralites’ craze for martial arts is nothing new. The history of Kalaripayattu goes back centuries. The post-Independence years of the 20th century saw a revival of interest in it, thanks to the efforts of teachers such as C.V. Narayanan Nair and

(Top & left) Sparring sessions in progress at JB Fit Club in Thiruvananthapuram; and (below) Chilean actor Eyal Meyer during a Kalaripayattu training session. JAYAMOCHAN A., SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

Chirakkal T. Sreedharan Nair. How the current influx of foreign combat arts would influence Kalaripayattu remains to be seen.

In the late 1970s, Karate came to Keralam with a big bang, riding on the excitement generated by Bruce Lee’s 1973 movie *Enter the Dragon*. Notably, the Japanese martial art made its entrance not directly from Japan but via Tamil Nadu and Sri Lanka. “Those days, youngsters studied Karate in secret, as parents tended to frown upon it. Today, they are more receptive,” says K. Nagulanathan, who teaches the Shotokan style of Karate in Thrissur. Nagulanathan had come to Keralam from Kilinochchi in Sri Lanka in 1981 and settled here to teach Karate. He does not believe that the entry of sports such as MMA has displaced Karate. The number of students has, in fact, increased, although their aspirations have changed, he says.

But this is where things get really interesting. In the midst of this martial arts ‘outbreak,’ there is also heightened interest in Kalaripayattu in its homeland.

“There is a revival. During a visit to Bengaluru, I was astonished to see the number of people taking up Kalaripayattu. People are also more aware about Kalaripayattu’s influence on other art forms,” says S.R.D. Prasad, an octogenarian Gurukkal (senior trainer), who runs the Sree Bharath Kalari at Valapattanam, Kannur. His father Chirakkal Sreedharan Nair had established the Kalari in 1948. The renewed interest, he says, is due to many factors, not least the Union government picking Kalaripayattu veterans for the coveted Padma Awards. Recipients include Mee-nakshi Amma, Sankara Narayana Menon Chundayil and Prasad himself. Prasad adds that Kalaripayattu teachers have also been forced to adapt to changing requirements.

Renewed interest in Kalaripayattu

In Thiruvananthapuram, the CVN Kalari continues to be a go-to place for Kalaripayattu enthusiasts. G. Sathyanarayanan, the grandson of C.V. Narayanan Nair, concurs that there is a renewed interest in Kalaripayattu. “A lot of the interest in Kalari is fuelled by the internet,” he notes. While changing times indeed call for changed strategies, it is still preferable to start the training between the ages of eight and 16, says Mr. Sathyanarayanan, who is now the Gurukkal at CVN Kalari. “Because the body is still supple and Kalaripayattu is not like other sports. It is an integrated system, and the body has to be prepared for structured training.”

Back in Chile, Meyer dreams of a sequel to *The Fist of the Condor*. “I hope so! I always tell Marko (Zaror) and Ernesto (Ernesto Diaz Espinoza, the film’s director) that we should do a second part that has more fighting sequences using Kalaripayattu’s weapons like the urumi. I have not seen that showcased in Western movies,” he says. Meyer has trained with the Kozhikode-based Hindustan Kalari Sangam, which he first contacted in 2008. “I finally arrived there in August 2011, where I was received openly and with warmth by everyone,” he recalls. He has since been to Keralam a number of times. He has his own take on Kalaripayattu’s prospects. “I don’t agree with the argument that it is a relic art. It is such a wise and profound technology for the body and mind that I feel it is more current than one thinks,” he notes.

A photograph of a coastal scene. In the foreground, a large, dark palm tree trunk leans from the left. Several colorful wooden boats, painted in yellow, blue, and green, are moored along a sandy beach. One boat is partially submerged in the water, while others are on the shore. In the background, a wide body of water (likely a river or lagoon) stretches towards a distant shoreline with green vegetation under a clear sky. A small boat with people is visible in the middle ground.

Fisherfolk crossing Vynateya at Odalarevu fish landing centre in Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema district. (Below) The crew after being sighted by two fishing boats 16 kilometres away from Shankarpur fishing harbour in West Bengal. T. APPALA NAIDU, BY ARRANGEMENT

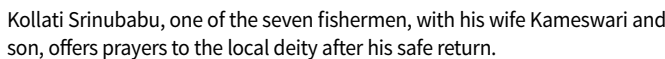
What started as a 15-day maiden fishing trip for seven fishermen from Konaseema district, quickly became a nightmare after their boat's engine failure left them drifting helplessly at sea and bringing them close encounters with giant creatures like whales. **T. Appala Naidu** highlights the harrowing ordeal.

What started as a 15-day maiden fishing trip for seven fishermen from Konaseema district, quickly became a nightmare after their boat's engine failure left them drifting helplessly at sea and bringing them close encounters with giant creatures like whales. **T. Appala Naidu** highlights the harrowing ordeal.

"We had three cell phones on board; mine was



By August 7, the boat had been driven by the winds nearly 200 nautical miles away from the Visakhapatnam coast. "In the deep sea, we stopped fishing because we were scared of the giant fish species. We saw one giant fish, believed to be a whale, that came close to our boat. It could have overturned our boat. We were frightened to see the size of the creatures found in the sea," recall Ramakrishna and the driver, Srinubabu. While the seven men struggled to keep the boat moving, life continued as usual for their families back home. Santa Rao's family, including



RAMAKRISHNA
Fisherman

State Agriculture Minister and Dr. B.R. Ambedkar Konaseema District In-Charge Minister K. Atchannaidu assured the families on August 19 that the State government has alerted the administrations and fishing boat associations in Odisha and West Bengal.

“My boat is still anchored on the West Bengal coast. If we had not returned, I would have been blamed for the loss of the lives of my crew for the rest of my life,” he says. The 49-year-old who is survived by his wife, daughter, and son, has decided to quit deep-sea fishing. He began his voyage hoping for a boatful of tuna, instead returned with an experience for a lifetime. “Our survival was the wish of God,” he says.

INBRIEF



Italy’s market regulator okays
Tata Motors unit’s offer papers

Italian market regulator CONSOB has given approval to the offer document of a Tata Motors Ltd. step-down subsidiary for the acquisition of common shares of Italian truck maker Iveco Group NV for €14.10 a share, including dividend. The voluntary offer will open on September 7, 2026 and close on October 26, 2026. If the legal formalities are complete, the offer will reopen for 5 days in early November 2026, according to an exchange filing. The acquisition is being done by TML CV Holdings B.V, a wholly owned subsidiary of TML CV Holdings Pte. Ltd., which is a wholly owned subsidiary of Tata Motors Ltd. In July 2025, the Tata Motors subsidiary had signed an agreement to acquire Iveco Group N.V. for ₹38,000 crore (\$4.5 billion).

SEBI presses ahead against
Hindenburg in Adani case

India’s markets regulator has started hearing representations as it seeks to recover gains from trades it suspects benefited from prior knowledge of Hindenburg Research’s scathing report about Adani Group, two people with knowledge of the matter said. The regulator has started personal hearings more than two years later as the parties involved took time to respond, the people said. All parties are based overseas but SEBI believes it has jurisdiction since the trades were in India, they said. SEBI is proceeding with enforcement, arguing that the trades were based on non-public information and so violated rules aimed at preventing fraud, said one of the people. To secure assets for recovery, SEBI has opposed court-supervised insolvency proceedings in Mauritius for the Kotak fund - K India Opportunities Fund Class F - used to execute the trades, the people said. Proceeds of the trades went into the fund, they said. REUTERS

NSE gets SEBI nod for
₹30,000-crore IPO

The Hindu Bureau
MUMBAI

The National Stock Exchange of India (NSE) has received regulatory approval to proceed with its ₹30,000 crore initial public offering (IPO), potentially making it the second-largest IPO in India after the proposed Jio Platforms.

The Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI) issued a letter of observation to the NSE, clearing the bourse’s Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) for the public offering.

NSE filed its DRHP on June 17 after its much-anticipated IPO was delayed for almost a decade amid regulatory and legal issues.

The proposed IPO will be entirely an offer for sale (OFS) with existing shareholders looking to sell up to 14.89 crore equity shares



The IPO may be the second largest after Jio Platforms.

or about 6% of NSE’s paid-up capital. There would be no fresh issue. Among the existing shareholders planning to offload stakes, the SBI Group is expected to be the largest seller, offering up to 2.475 crore shares. Other major shareholders participating in the OFS include MS Strategic (Mauritius) Ltd. and Canada Pension Plan Investment Board (CPPIB).

Tata Chemicals’ Kenya unit ordered
to close; firm says all rules followed

Lalatendu Mishra
NAIROBI

In a major setback for Tata Chemicals Ltd., the Government of Kenya has ordered the closure of Tata Chemicals Magadi Ltd., a subsidiary making soda ash, for ‘non-contribution to the local economy.’

Reportedly, Kenya’s President William Ruto , who ordered the firm to stop operations, said two new firms be roped in to take over the operations.

Acknowledging the development, Tata Chemicals said in a filing, it had received the official com-



Two new firms are to be roped in to take over operations.

munication from the Ministry of Mining, Blue Economy and Maritime Affairs (Ministry) dated July 28, 2026. “We reiterate on August 11, Tata Chemicals Magadi Ltd. (TCML) submit-

Thermal sector grapples
with coal stock management

Generators that maintain adequate coal inventories are at risk of being disadvantaged when limited domestic supplies are redirected to plants that fall below prescribed stock norms

Lalatendu Mishra
MUMBAI

India’s thermal power sector faces a growing fuel management dilemma with generators that maintain adequate coal inventories risk being disadvantaged when limited domestic supplies are redirected to plants that fall below prescribed stock norms.

While such emergency interventions may be necessary to keep vulnerable plants operational and safeguard grid reliability, industry stakeholders warn that repeated redistribution could undermine incentives for generators to plan and maintain adequate fuel stocks.

Coal stock requirements for thermal power plants have been in place for years. The current Central Electricity Authority (CEA) framework took effect on December 6, 2021, introducing revised, plant-specific stocking norms aimed at strengthening fuel security and inventory planning.

Supply framework

The broader coal supply framework – including coal linkages, Fuel Supply Agreements (FSAs) and other supply arrangements – is intended to provide generators with greater certainty over fuel availability and allow them to plan inventories more effectively.

The revised SHAKTI policy, approved by the Cen-



Fair cause: Emergency redistribution, it is felt, should be reserved for genuine supply-chain disruptions. SIVA SARAVANAN S.

tral Government in May 2025, further streamlined coal-linkage allocation into two windows.

Allocation windows

Window I provides coal linkages to central government-owned generating companies and state utilities at notified prices, while Window II allows other eligible producers, including imported-coal-based plants, to procure coal through auctions at a premium over the notified price.

The ministries of Coal, Power and Railways also coordinate regularly to monitor coal supplies and facilitate movement to power plants, particularly during periods of supply disruption, such as what emerged during the COVID-19 pandemic when all modes of transport came to a standstill, necessitating CEA’s revised coal supply framework.

Emergency assistance

entire logistics chain, including production, loading, railway availability, transit, unloading and stockyard management.

Emergency redistribution, he said, should therefore be reserved for genuine supply-chain disruptions such as mine-side constraints, railway bottlenecks, force-majeure events or unexpected spikes in electricity demand.

India’s coal production exceeded 1 billion tonnes in each of the last two financial years, reaching 1,047.52 million tonnes (MT) in FY2024-25 and 1,040.08 MT in FY2025-26.

In the current financial year, cumulative production through July stood at 302.04 MT, while overall coal dispatches rose about 6% year-on-year to 354.7 million tonnes.

Government data showed coal stocks at thermal power plants at 34.55 MT, with another 113 MT either at pitheads or in transit. The combined stock was therefore around 148 MT.

The figures indicate that the challenge is not necessarily a shortage of coal at the national level, but how efficiently supplies are allocated, transported and converted into adequate plant-level inventories.

The issue has gained importance as electricity demand continues to rise and thermal generation remains central to meeting peak requirements.

No takers for govt’s
₹37,500-crore coal
gasification scheme

Press Trust of India
NEW DELHI

The government’s ambitious ₹37,500-crore financial incentive scheme for the promotion of coal gasification has found no taker so far, according to sources.

Despite the September 7 deadline, the scheme has received no application from any private or public player to set up projects under the programme, raising concerns over the viability of the coal ministry’s push to gasify 75 million tonnes of coal and lignite, sources said.

Unless the deadline of September 7 is over, it would not be possible to state the number of applications since the whole process is online, the coal ministry said in an emailed response.

The ministry has received communication from several industries expressing interest in participating in the scheme, it said. In a notice, the coal ministry had said that “the Request for Proposal (RFP) dated July 7, 2026, issued under the ₹37,500 crore financial incentive scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects, wherein the last date for submission of applications is September 7, 2026.” It is pertinent to inform that given the scale of funds involved in coal gasification projects, the preparation of PFRs and project proposals requires time, the ministry said, adding that application rounds are



Union Minister Ashwini Vaishnaw briefing the media on the scheme in May. FILE PHOTO

envisaged every two months, providing multiple opportunities for industry participation.

The Union Cabinet had earlier approved the scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing dependence on forex-guzzling imports of LNG, urea, and methanol, while insulating the country from global price volatility and supply chain disruptions.

The Union Cabinet under the chairmanship of Prime Minister Narendra Modi approved the scheme for promotion of surface coal/lignite gasification projects with a financial outlay of ₹37,500 crore.

Coal gasification refers to the process of converting dry fuel into synthetic gas (syngas), which is used as an alternative fuel and helps reduce carbon emissions. This process supports production of methanol, fertilisers, hydrogen and chemicals, cutting reliance on imports.

‘This GDP growth number did
not come out of nowhere’

The fact that we didn’t have an upward revision to India’s FY26 GDP numbers under the new methodology shows that we are doing a good job: Chief Economic Advisor says on GDP numbers

INTERVIEW

V Anantha
Nageswaran

Raghuvir Srinivasan
CHENNAI

Questions have been raised by some commentators over the veracity of the first quarter FY27 GDP data released by the Centre. *businessline* caught up over phone with the Chief Economic Advisor V. Anantha Nageswaran, who’s travelling in the U.S., to understand the correct picture.

Edited excerpts:

There is criticism that the real GDP growth in the first quarter of this fiscal is not 7.8% but just 2.6%. Is this valid?

The ₹86 lakh crore first quarter GDP estimate of last year was based on the old base year and the old methodology. So, how can you even compare that? If you want to compare ₹86 lakh crore, you have to estimate a number that would have been the case had the old series continued and the old methodology continued. That number could be in the mid-90s. Then you can compare. But you are taking ₹86 lakh crore, which was under 2011-12 base year and under the old methodology, and then taking the new number of ₹88 lakh crore under the 2022-23 base year under the new methodology, and arriving at 2.2% or 2.3% no-



minal GDP growth, which is unsustainable. You have to have a common platform, common basis to compare numbers.

Was the use of double deflator the only reason behind the downward revision of last year number, or were there other reasons?

There are multiple reasons. It is very difficult to spell them all out. Mospi (Statistics Ministry) had put them out. When you have better methodologies, better coverage, more number of items that are being sampled... there are many reasons and it is difficult to list them.

And then, a lot of things were imputed under the old methodology. Now, we have the data. So, there are a combination of reasons.

In some cases, in fact, I would say, if we were not covering a particular sector well at all, such as informal economy, and now we cover them much better, then in fact, GDP numbers would go up.

The fact that we didn’t have an upward revision to India’s FY26 GDP numbers under the new methodolo-

gy shows that we were actually doing a fairly good job of covering all sectors of the economy. So, if anything, this shows the rigour of the approach that has been followed.

So, is the double deflator approach a statistically superior method, or is it just that we are using it because multilateral agencies and the United Nations have prescribed that?

It is obviously both factors at work here. First of all, it is a prescribed methodology. Obviously, such a prescription wouldn’t have happened had it not been for the fact that just like in India, there are lots of statistical experts who go through these approaches and then recommend that this is the more reliable and more accurate way to capture what is going on in the economy.

That is how it becomes part of the suggested method by multilateral agencies and many countries follow it. So, the prescription itself doesn’t arise in a vacuum. And double deflator, especially in manufactur-

ing, has one separate for input and one separate for output. When input prices go up, it is not always possible that output prices would rise in the same proportion.

So, in the the case of India, many input prices come from overseas markets. Whereas the output prices are governed by domestic economic dynamics. So, it makes sense to have double deflator method.

Is the 7.8% number in Q1FY27 a correct reflection of the underlying growth impulse in the economy?

First of all, I have to clarify I am myself very rigorous and skeptical of any bullish claims unless I have been able to verify it through my own processes.

If you are trying to understand the 7.8%, look at the fact that GST collections, e-way bill generation, auto sales, export growth performance, bank credit growth in the last two quarters or so, all of them in fact were pointing to a GDP growth estimate for 2026-27 first quarter to be of a high number. So, this GDP growth number did not come out of nowhere. It is well backed by more frequent indicators, more verifiable indicators which we have seen because banks are lending and that is there in the credit data that RBI puts out. (The writer is Editor, The Hindu Businessline)

Russian drone strikes Ukraine security service headquarters



Israeli Minister hails capture of Hezbollah highland in Lebanon



Trump says he will ask Europeans to repay the U.S. for aiding Ukraine



Sri Lanka anti-graft authorities nab ex-President's son over Airbus deal



CM
YK



Lin Chia-Lung speaks at a press conference on the sidelines of the 55th Pacific Islands Forum in Palau on Sept. 1. AFP

Taiwan accuses China of ‘wolf warrior’ tactics

Reuters
TAIPEI

Taiwan Foreign Minister Lin Chia-Lung condemned China’s “wolf warrior” diplomacy at this week’s forum of Pacific Islands leaders, and said Chinese officials had also engaged in espionage at the event.

This year’s meeting of the Pacific Islands Forum was overshadowed by China’s objections to the presence of Taiwan at the summit, saying Taipei was not qualified to attend and that its presence would have consequences.

Summit host Palau is one of three Pacific island countries with official diplomatic ties to Chinese-claimed Taiwan. Beijing says Taiwan is one of its Provinces and not a country, a view the government in Taipei strongly rejects.

Speaking to reporters in Taipei on Friday, Mr. Lin said China’s remarks at the summit were not welcome. “This kind of Chinese ‘wolf warrior’ diplomacy actually easily undermines Pacific unity, and it is quite off-putting and disliked,” he said, adding that Taiwan and China were both invited guests.

“Wolf warrior” diplomacy, which takes its name from a popular Chinese movie franchise, refers to strong remarks by Chinese officials in public, marking a departure from the restraint generally seen previously.

“This kind of threatening language and behaviour – claiming there will be ‘serious consequences,’ even going so far as to declare Palau an ‘unsafe travel destination’ – is extremely absurd and ironic for Pacific nations,” he added, referring to a travel warning China issued for Palau last month. Mr. Lin also expressed concern about Chinese officials’ activities at the summit.

Nepal wants climate compensation, putting major emitters on the hook

Following the catastrophic glacial collapse and flash flood on August 26, Nepal is demanding climate compensation from the world’s biggest emitters; by shifting the framework from charity to liability, the small Himalayan country has turned a devastating tragedy into a global test of climate justice

NEWS ANALYSIS

Shikha Kumari A.

“We are paying the ultimate price for a global crisis we did not create,” Nepal’s Foreign Minister Shisir Khanal declared on September 1, after a catastrophic glacial collapse that killed over 1,200 people. But in the aftermath of this “Himalayan tsunami”, Nepal is doing something that is quite unprecedented. Instead of just issuing the usual appeals for humanitarian aid, Kathmandu has launched a diplomatic offensive. They are demanding direct climate compensation from the world’s three biggest emitters: the United States, China, and India. By shifting foreign policy from seeking charity to enforcing legal liability, Nepal has turned a devastating tragedy into a global test of climate justice, which forces the international community to confront the harsh limits of adaptation.

The third pole paradox
The immediate challenge before these major emitters is reconciling the glaring climate injustice that Nepal actually represents. Nepal only contributes a negligible 0.1% of global greenhouse gas emissions, and generates almost all of

its electricity from renewable hydropower sources. And yet, its geography places it at the absolute ground zero of global warming. The Hindu Kush Himalayas, often referred to as the “Third Pole”, are warming at nearly twice the global average, melting the glaciers at 10 times their historical norms.

This accelerated melt is not occurring in a vacuum, however. It is driven by global “teleconnections”, meaning that warming in the North Eurasian Arctic disrupts planetary waves and the stratospheric polar vortex, which directly destabilises the South Asian monsoon. The August 26 disaster, which was triggered by a massive glacial collapse on the Nepal-China border, demonstrated how extreme events in the cryosphere can cascade down into densely populated valleys. The major powers basically mistook Nepal’s crisis for a localised weather event that could be managed with temporary relief. But the Himalayan ecosystem is sustained by a delicate climate balance that is now failing under the weight of Northern Hemisphere pollution.

Nepal’s strategy for economic sovereignty rested heavily on harnessing its 43,000 MW of commercially viable hydropower to become a regional energy exporter. It had only re-



Mired in mud: People scout for usable materials amid debris after the flash flood at Trishuli Center in Nepal’s Nuwakot district. AFP

cently achieved a net-exporter status. The August floods, however, crippled approximately 10% of the country’s installed capacity, wiping out older, surface-level plants like Devighat while completely burying under-construction projects in mud. Overnight, a nation that was banking on energy exports to narrow its trade deficit with India was forced to halt its exports and instead import power to survive the winter.

Rebuilding is going to require climate-resilient, underground engineering, driving up future project costs by 10% to 12%. The total damages are estimated between \$4 billion and \$7 billion, which amounts to roughly a tenth of Nepal’s entire GDP.

In its pursuit of climate justice, Nepal has explicitly named the United States, China, and India as the primary architects of its misery. The case against

the U.S. is anchored in historical liability, because America accounts for over 20% of cumulative global emissions since 1850.

China, which is the current top annual emitter, faces a different sort of indictment: geographic proximity and upstream negligence. During a bilateral meeting in Kathmandu back in May 2026, Nepali officials pleaded for real-time data-sharing on glacial lakes and avalanches from the Tibetan region. Beijing provided only heavy rain forecasts in response. When the glacial lake burst on August 26, the lack of transboundary early-warning systems proved to be fatal.

India, meanwhile, presents an “equity paradox”. For decades now, New Delhi has shielded itself in global forums by citing its low per-capita emissions and demanding “common but differentiated responsibilities” from the West. Nepal

is now taking that exact logic and applying it regionally: as South Asia’s economic and emitting giant, India owes a differentiated responsibility to its smaller, vulnerable neighbours. Yet, India’s geopolitical manoeuvring, such as refusing to buy power from Nepali projects built by Chinese contractors, has only complicated Nepal’s recovery efforts, expanding the friction horizontally across the region.

Climate finance trap

Consider the global climate finance architecture of the 21st century. At COP27 in 2022, vulnerable nations successfully fought to establish the Fund for Respondering to Loss and Damage (FRLD), which was then operationalised a year later at COP28. But in practice, the mechanism is severely handicapped by slow-moving bureaucracy. For a country in ruins, waiting months for a standard UN review is a luxury it cannot afford to take.

By bypassing the normal channels and launching an unprecedented, out-of-cycle demand on September 1, just six days after the disaster happened, Nepal has forced the board to decide if it can react to a real-time emergency, or if it is merely another paper-pushing exercise.

As a matter of fact, the entire global fund current-

ly holds a mere \$700 million in pledges. More tragically, under the fund’s pilot phase rules, individual grants are capped at between \$5 million and \$20 million, which means a \$20 million payout for a \$7 billion catastrophe lays bare the inability of the current system to provide meaningful compensation to anyone. Furthermore, with the fund being temporarily hosted by the World Bank, debt-saddled developing nations fear that “compensation” might ultimately morph into crippling loans later down the line.

Trapped in this financial labyrinth, the major powers have resorted to a familiar playbook. Rather than acknowledging any legal liability, China and India have flooded Nepal with traditional disaster relief like helicopters, rescue teams, and medicines.

But Nepal’s diplomatic gambit has already altered the landscape. Even if Kathmandu does not immediately extract a multi-billion-dollar cheque from the major emitters, its resolute stance has exposed the profound inadequacies of global climate diplomacy. Nepal has shifted the framework from charity to liability, setting a disruptive precedent for the entire Global South that the world’s heavy emitters will find increasingly difficult to just ignore.

U.K. asserts ‘unshakeable’ Falklands stance after Argentina revives claim

Agence France-Presse
LONDON

Britain insisted Friday that the Falkland Islands “are British” after Argentine President Javier Milei said the “winds of change” favoured his country’s claim to the archipelago, citing Washington’s readiness to review its neutrality in the dispute.

Britain and Argentina fought a 10-week war in 1982 over the South Atlantic islands, a British overseas territory which Argentines call Las Malvinas.

The fate of the islands hit headlines again in recent days after U.S. President Donald Trump threatened to wade into the dispute, and an British-Israeli oil project near the is-



Britain and Argentina fought a 10-week war in 1982 over Falklands, a British overseas territory that Argentina calls Las Malvinas. AP

lands caused anger in Argentina.

In an address on national TV, Mr. Milei assured Thursday that Argentina would not “stand idly by” in the face of the oil project and announced sanctions on firms linked to oil extraction “in Argentine territory under British occu-

pation.” “There are winds of change in the world that are favourable to our claim,” he said, alluding to Mr. Trump’s threat to withdraw support for Britain’s sovereignty.

Control of the Falklands is a highly emotive issue in Argentina, even though the islanders themselves

voted overwhelmingly in 2013 to remain British.

“The Falklands are British because Falkland Islanders choose to be British,” British Defence Secretary Wes Streeting responded in a social media post on Friday. “Our commitment to the Falklands is absolute and unshakeable,” Mr. Streeting added.

On Tuesday, Argentine Falklands War veterans and environmental lawyers filed a lawsuit to halt the oil project led by the British company Rockhopper and the Israeli company Navitas.

Mr. Milei said the project violated a United Nations resolution calling on both sides to desist from unilateral actions in the islands.

A toxic mountain



A helicopter conducts water bombing to extinguish a fire at the Putri Cempo landfill at Solo in Indonesia’s Central Java on Friday. AFP

Farage’s Reform UK meets as new donation scandal and resignations hit party

Agence France-Presse
BIRMINGHAM

British hard-right leader Nigel Farage’s Reform UK party gathered for its annual conference on Friday engulfed by a fresh scandal over allegations it flouted donations rules.

The Brexit figurehead was hoping to use the meeting to move on from multiple controversies over financial gifts that has dented his anti-immigration party’s standing in opinion polls.

But just hours before Mr. Farage’s keynote address, two senior Reform officials resigned following an undercover investigation aired by Channel 4 News that alleged they had conspired to secure a foreign donation – barred under U.K. electoral law.

Delegates at the conference in the central English city of Birmingham played down the allegations.

Heather Kynman condemned the timing of the broadcast as “absolutely outrageous”.

“I just think they [opponents] are so worried about Reform, it’s attack, attack, attack all the time,” the 62-year-old nurse told AFP, adding that Mr. Farage had her full backing.

“I think [Farage] is absolutely brilliant. He’s the one leader that is showing real backbone. What he’s saying now has never changed,” she said.

Reform said in a statement that party policy head James Orr and Mr. Farage’s longtime aide Dan Jukes had stepped down from their roles pending the outcome of an internal

probe. The ruling Labour party was among rival parties to say they had reported Reform to police over claims it took funding from a U.S. firm for three opinion polls it commissioned earlier this year.

The purported donors were in fact undercover reporters for investigative journalism group Verbatim. London’s Metropolitan police said it was “aware” of the reports.

‘Broken no laws’

Mr. Farage, 62, insisted in an interview with LBC radio that Reform had “broken no laws” and was the victim of “entrapment”.

In Birmingham, conference delegate Darren Ball predicted the furore would not knock Reform’s prospects.

“I think Reform will cer-



Natural allies: Jordan Bardella, left, and Nigel Farage share stage during Reform UK’s annual conference at Birmingham on Friday. AP

tainly be in power. We need it. Reform is the only party that can save this country. Immigration is a huge thing for the U.K. It needs to be addressed,” the 51-year-old who works in security said.

Firebrand Farage, who is eyeing the keys to No 10 Downing Street, has been seeking to regain the mo-

mentum that saw Reform chalk up significant success at May local elections.

Until late July, Reform had led centre-left Labour in polls for over a year, but it has recently slipped behind with Mr. Farage facing intense scrutiny over his finances and Labour enjoying a bounce under new Prime Minister Andy Burn-

ham. Parliament’s sleaze watchdog is already investigating a £5 million (\$6.7 million) donation from British crypto-currency billionaire Christopher Harborne to Mr. Farage, who has said the money was for his security.

He says it was received before he was elected and therefore did not need to be declared to parliamentary authorities.

John Howard, 62, a property developer and aspiring Reform candidate from Ipswich in eastern England, said the new potential scandal was “disappointing” but insisted it was “just a blip”.

“We’ll see whether they [the officials] are guilty of anything serious. If they are, they won’t come back clearly, and the party will learn from it,” he said.

He conceded that the party had its work cut out for it since Mr. Burnham had replaced unpopular former Labour Prime Minister Keir Starmer.

‘Asset’ to ‘vulnerable’

Mr. Farage remains Reform’s most recognisable figure with his party’s rise closely tied to his political persona as a plain-speaking, anti-establishment populist.

The party’s main focus is its anti-immigration policies, in particular ending the arrival of thousands of irregular migrants by small boat on England’s southern coast.

Mr. Farage had been the “big asset for Reform for some years” but was now “looking pretty vulnerable”, Paul Whiteley, professor of government at the

University of Essex, told AFP ahead of the conference.

Reform’s deputy leader, Richard Tice, is also facing allegations that he failed to declare financial gifts.

Reform hopes to establish itself as the ruling Labour Party’s main challenger on the right. It currently has just eight seats in the 650-seat Westminster Parliament despite securing 14% of the vote at the 2024 general election.

But it also faces competition from Reform defector Rupert Lowe’s far-right Restore Britain that has eaten into Reform’s support.

The conference will later be addressed by Jordan Bardella, president of France’s anti-immigrant, eurosceptic National Rally (RN) party, ahead of Mr. Farage’s speech.

Weekend Sport



Mature Gurindervir battles stopwatch, questions, injuries

India's fastest man has endured a challenging few months since breaching the 10.1-second barrier. Ahead of the Asian Games, he is determined to take control of his life and his running

Uthra Ganesan

Two years ago, Gurindervir Singh stamped his return to the top rung of sprinters in India by winning the National Inter-State Athletics Championships in the fading light at Panchkula. It was only 10.32 seconds, but it brought him the spotlight and support needed to kick his almost stagnant career back into gear. In time, it led to him becoming the fastest Indian on the track, raising expectations of a historic sub-10 run in the most glamorous event in athletics.

Familiar situation

As the 25-year-old prepares for the upcoming Asian Games, the parallels between 2024 and now are hard to miss, even for the man himself. Back then, Gurindervir was the meet record holder at the Nationals, but, in the three years since he had clocked 10.27s (Patiala, 2021), others had raced far ahead. Coupled with injuries, lack of sufficient nutrition and uncertainty over his sporting future, he had been forced to play catch-up. Now, with the all-important continental meet looming large, Gurindervir is again battling the stopwatch on the track and questions and injuries off it. The only Indian to go under 10.1s has had a torrid few months ever since the incredible two days in May when the national record switched hands thrice, Gurindervir eventually making it his own in 10.09s. He injured his hamstring, crashed out in the first round at the Commonwealth Games and finished a lowly seventh at the World Athletics Con-

That Gurindervir took pressure. This one has evolved, he has learnt from all this

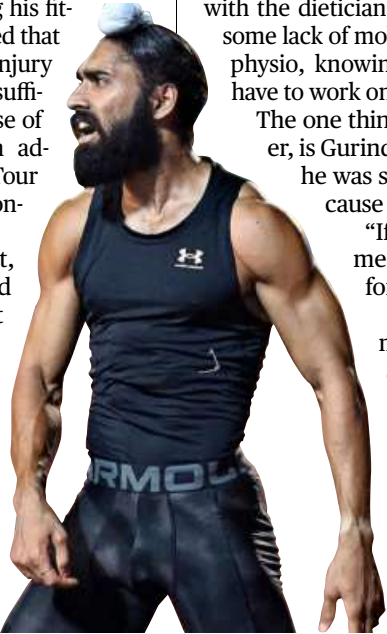
GURINDERVIR

tinental Tour in Bhubaneswar. The big difference now, however, is the support he has access to. Picked up by the Reliance Foundation after the 2024 outing and working under the watchful eyes of its athletics director James Hillier at the high performance centre in Navi Mumbai, Gurindervir is already back to peak training ahead of his biggest outing of the year. "He's had a good couple of weeks of training. He's getting back into good shape but he's looking to get into peak 100m shape within the next two weeks. That's what I'm hoping for," Hillier said before getting into the details of Gurindervir's technical strengths and weaknesses. "CWG... there were certain elements of his race that were quite good from a coaching perspective. I'm very happy with the first 60-70 meters of his race. What we've been working on in the last few weeks is getting him to extrapolate that speed over the full 100m. "We've been working pretty hard to get that last bit of the race sorted. I've put some specific training in place for that. We have a competition in Delhi on September 10 and that's going to be a key competition. We'll get to see exactly where he is, where the training is going and how well he finishes the race there, that'll give us very good information," Hillier explained. The transformation The man himself has gone from being an emotional and often-stressed youngster to a more confident and mature professional who is determined to take control of his life and his running, something Hillier also acknowledged. The transformation began in March last year, when he

broke the national record for the first time with a 10.20s run at the Indian Grand Prix 1. Gurindervir had been battling stomach ulcers that weakened his body and naysayers who tried to break his spirit. Both were spillovers from his time in obscurity before 2024 – when a poor diet and dirty water stripped away his gut lining. He could barely keep anything in and lost almost 15kgs in a fortnight even as people, known and unknown, sniggered that he was finished. "If you had asked last year's Gurindervir about handling the pressure, maybe he would have been in stress. That time too, all this happened with me – interviews, phone calls, questions, expectations. I was not sleeping at night," he said. "Back then, I couldn't get out of it. I was thinking about what to say in the next interview when I should have been thinking about how to improve. When I ran in the Fed Cup [in 2025], I cramped and it stressed me even more because I had claimed I would do a lot in the interviews. That Gurindervir took pressure. This one has evolved, he has learnt from all this." A large part of the credit for that, he insisted, went to Hillier for keeping him away from a lot of negativity. "If it wasn't for him, I would have been in a very bad, stressful situation. The coach motivated me a lot. He gave me the right guidance on how to deal with it." A lot of people had been critical of his inclusion for Glasgow, questioning his fitness, but Hillier has already clarified that the problem was not carrying an injury into competition but the lack of sufficient races before the CWG because of the injury. That issue has been addressed although the Continental Tour event highlighted the issues that continue to plague his race plan. "At the Bhubaneswar event, you'll see he was in a really good position at 60-70m and then sort of fell away, which I expected to happen based on what's been happening in training. It's just how he's put together," Hillier said. "Many 100m athletes run the race in different ways. Guri is a very good accelerator and that's just his natural strength. He won



I'm very happy with the first 60-70 meters of his race. What we've been working on in the last few weeks is getting him to extrapolate that speed over the full 100m JAMES HILLIER Athletics director, Reliance Foundation the national indoor 60m earlier in the year, broke the national record in that with a very fast time of 6.60s. Someone like an Animesh [Kujur] or an Amlan [Borgohain], these guys tend to finish strong, that's their natural strength. We must train them to their strengths and then work alongside that to manage their weaknesses." Listening to his body Gurindervir has also learnt to listen to his body. "I have worked on everything. What I eat and how much, how much I travel. If I am feeling any pain, how much effort do I have to put into the workout? If I am doing an endurance workout, how do I do it? "In weight training, I have set levels I must achieve every month. It's the same on track as well. I will train as much as my body needs. I discuss with the dietician how much food I need. I had some lack of mobility before, so sitting with the physio, knowing which muscles and joints I have to work on so that I can run better." The one thing that hasn't changed, however, is Gurindervir's conviction. The reason he was stressed, he explained, was because what he says matters to him. "If I say something, it has to have meaning. Words are important for me. "If I claim or promise something and I cannot do it, it affects me. That's my nature. My father had a dream, I started running to fulfil that dream. People said Indians can't be competitive in 100m, I was determined to do it. It will take some time, but it will definitely happen."



STACKING UP



ATP Men's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Jannik Sinner	25	12,800	17
2	Alexander Zverev	29	7,790	20
3	Carlos Alcaraz	23	7,160	17
4	Felix Auger-Aliassime	26	4,640	22
5	Novak Djokovic	39	3,770	16
6	Flavio Cobolli	24	3,720	26
7	Alex de Minaur	27	3,650	24
8	Daniil Medvedev	30	3,580	24
9	Ben Shelton	23	3,480	22
10	Taylor Fritz	28	3,475	22
11	Arthur Fils	22	3,140	18
12	Frances Tiafoe	28	2,680	22
13	Rafael Jodar	19	2,671	22
14	Lorenzo Musetti	24	2,605	22
15	Learner Tien	20	2,565	22



Top Indians ▶

 Sumit Nagal Rank 236 ▼ 2 spots	 Dhakshinewar Suresh Rank 368 ▲ 26 spots
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WTA Women's Top 15

#	Player	Age	Points	Events
1	Aryna Sabalenka	28	8,575	18
2	Elena Rybakina	27	8,141	21
3	Jessica Pegula	32	7,265	19
4	Coco Gauff	22	6,704	18
5	Mirra Andreeva	19	5,443	20
6	Linda Noskova	21	5,028	20
7	Karolina Muchova	30	4,983	20
8	Iga Swiatek	25	4,809	19
9	Elina Svitolina	31	4,689	17
10	Amanda Anisimova	25	4,533	15
11	Marta Kostyuk	24	3,980	16
12	Belinda Bencic	29	2,995	18
13	Naomi Osaka	28	2,846	18
14	Iva Jovic	18	2,671	23
15	Victoria Mboko	20	2,531	19

Top Indians ▶

 Sahaja Yamalapalli Rank 341 ▲ 1 spot	 Vaishnavi Adkar Rank 392 ▲ 3 spots
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F1 Drivers' standings

#	Driver	Team	Points	Wins
1	A.K. Antonelli	Mercedes	242	6
2	G. Russell	Mercedes	183	2
3	L. Hamilton	Ferrari	183	1
4	L. Norris	McLaren	159	2
5	C. Leclerc	Ferrari	155	1
6	M. Verstappen	Red Bull	112	0
7	O. Piastri	McLaren	104	0
8	I. Hadjar	Red Bull	68	0
9	L. Lawson	RB	49	0
10	P. Gasly	Alpine	44	0
11	A. Lindblad	RB	23	0
12	F. Colapinto	Alpine	19	0
13	O. Bearman	Haas	18	0
14	G. Bortoleto	Audi	10	0
15	N. Hulkenberg	Audi	6	0
16	C. Sainz	Williams	6	0
17	A. Albon	Williams	5	0
18	E. Ocon	Haas	3	0
19	F. Alonso	Aston Martin	3	0
20	V. Bottas	Cadillac	0	0
21	S. Perez	Cadillac	0	0
22	L. Stroll	Aston Martin	0	0



A.K. Antonelli



G. Russell

F1 Constructors' standings

Pos	Team	Points	Wins
1	Mercedes	425	8
2	Ferrari	338	2
3	McLaren	263	2
4	Red Bull	186	0
5	RB	66	0
6	Alpine	63	0
7	Haas	21	0
8	Audi	16	0
9	Williams	11	0
10	Aston Martin	3	0
11	Cadillac	0	0



Badminton Men's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	Jonatan Christie	87,631	17
2	Christo Popov	87,002	20
3	Kunlavut Vitidsarn	86,915	16
4	Chou Tien Chen	86,580	27
5	Anders Antonsen	85,405	17
6	Shi Yu Qi	84,075	12
7	Alex Lanier	78,715	16
8	Kodai Naraoka	76,530	20
9	Victor Lai	76,465	18
10	Li Shi Feng	71,683	16
11	Alwi Farhan	71,619	19
12	Lin Chun-Yi	71,274	19
13	Lakshya Sen	65,573	21
14	Loh Kean Yew	64,100	20
15	Toma Junior Popov	62,697	20

Top Indians ▶

 Lakshya Sen Rank 13	 Ayush Shetty Rank 20
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Badminton Women's ranking

#	Player	Points	Events
1	An Se Young	1,21,287	15
2	Wang Zhi Yi	1,03,989	16
3	Akane Yamaguchi	1,02,576	18
4	Chen Yu Fei	86,651	15
5	Han Yue	77,038	14
6	Ratchanok Intanon	74,606	20
7	Putri Kusuma Wardani	72,023	18
8	Pornpawee Chochuwong	69,027	16
9	Tomoka Miyazaki	68,106	22
10	P.V. Sindhu	65,401	14
11	Nozomi Okuhara	63,610	18
12	Kim Ga Eun	60,931	16
13	Line Christophersen	57,940	22
14	Michelle Li	57,427	21
15	Mia Blichfeldt	55,803	13

Top Indians ▶

 P.V. Sindhu Rank 10	 Unnati Hooda Rank 25
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Test Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Harry Brook	856	898
2	Steve Smith	840	947
3	Joe Root	820	932
4	Travis Head	811	884
5	Temba Bavuma	775	806
6	Rachin Ravindra	740	740
7	Rishabh Pant	713	801
8	Daryl Mitchell	710	804
9	Shubman Gill	709	807
10	Kamindu Mendis	706	784

ODI Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Shubman Gill	801	841
2	Daryl Mitchell	794	840
3	Virat Kohli	767	908
4	Rohit Sharma	758	879
5	Ibrahim Zadran	719	756
6	Babar Azam	689	894
7	Joe Root	674	810
8	Shai Hope	673	782
9	Charith Asalanka	659	705
10	Harry Tector	653	730

T20I Batting

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Ishan Kishan	910	910
2	Sahibzada Farhan	848	848
3	Abhishek Sharma	819	931
4	Dewald Brevis	806	806
5	Phil Salt	799	881
6	Pathum Nissanka	751	796
7	Tilak Varma	750	845
8	Jos Buttler	748	794
9	Harry Brook	734	734
10	Mitchell Marsh	706	706

Test Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Mitchell Starc	872	872
2	Matt Henry	861	870
3	Jasprit Bumrah	853	908
4	Pat Cummins	841	914
5	Ollie Robinson	831	831
6	Marco Jansen	825	825
7	Kagiso Rabada	807	902
8	Scott Boland	804	820
9	Noman Ali	785	853
10	Josh Hazlewood	783	864

ODI Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	714	775
2	Abrar Ahmed	675	675
3	Jofra Archer	649	682
4	Keshav Maharaj	645	737
5	Mitchell Santner	644	656
6	Maheesh Theekshana	641	680
7	Bernard Scholtz	613	631
8	Shaheen Afridi	604	691
9	Mehidy Hasan	602	722
10	Adil Rashid	599	671

T20I Bowling

#	Player	Rating	Career best
1	Rashid Khan	753	828
2	Abrar Ahmed	736	757
3	Adil Rashid	710	747
4	Adam Zampa	700	746
5	Nathan Ellis	675	678
6	Wanindu Hasaranga	668	809
7	Mujeeb Ur Rahman	663	757
7	Varun Chakaravarthy	663	818
9	Mohammad Nawaz	658	672
9	Maheesh Theekshana	658	686

